

Workplace Innovation & Future Skills Training Program

- *Part of initial vocational training* -

Work Package 4.1 - Activity 4.1

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Workplace Innovation & Future Skills



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Introduction

Modern vocational training must prepare learners not only for the technical tasks of a profession but also for active participation in improving how work is organised, carried out, and developed. Small and medium-sized enterprises in particular rely on employees who can contribute ideas, handle change constructively, and support continuous improvement. These expectations correspond directly to the competence levels defined in the European Qualifications Framework for EQF levels 3 and 4.

At EQF level 3, learners are expected to apply factual knowledge and use basic methods to solve routine problems. They should take responsibility for completing assigned tasks and adapt their behaviour to workplace needs. Introducing workplace innovation at this level strengthens their ability to recognise simple improvement opportunities, participate in team-based problem solving, and develop confidence in contributing ideas.

At EQF level 4, learners are required to handle more complex work situations, interpret information, and solve non-routine problems. They are expected to manage their work within given guidelines, take responsibility for evaluating results, and occasionally guide others. Integrating workplace innovation into training supports these requirements by helping learners analyse work processes, assess improvement options, and implement practical solutions.

By embedding workplace innovation into vocational training, learners develop knowledge, skills, and responsibilities that go beyond technical proficiency. They learn to work collaboratively, apply digital tools, reflect on work practices, communicate effectively, and propose improvements. These competencies are essential in dynamic workplaces where adaptability, initiative, and continuous learning are key to long-term employability and organisational competitiveness.

As part of the WIN4SMEs project, the CoVEs developed a comprehensive strategy program (see Result 4.12 Differentiation in Vocational Training Strategy Program). Addressed is initial vocational training. These trainings address vocational education and can be offered as additional training or as part of existing curricula.

These modules are self-standing and can be integrated separately or cumulatively:

Module 1: Introduction to Workplace Innovation

Learners gain an overview of workplace innovation and its importance to modern SMEs. They explore simple examples and identify potential improvement opportunities in their own training company.

Module 2: Participatory Problem Solving and Teamwork

Learners practice structured methods for solving problems together, such as group analysis and idea generation. They apply these methods to a real or simulated task from their work environment.

Module 3: Digital Tools for Innovation

Learners are introduced to basic digital tools that support communication, planning, and process improvement. They use one or more tools to complete a small task that demonstrates practical value for workplace routines.

Module 4: Sustainability and Social Responsibility at Work

Learners examine how environmental and social considerations influence daily work practices. They develop a small improvement idea that supports sustainable behaviour in their company or workshop.

Module 5: Entrepreneurship and Intrapreneurship

Learners explore how entrepreneurial thinking can be applied inside an organization to create value. They work on a simple product, service, or process idea and outline how it could benefit their company.

Module 6: Communication and Change Management

Learners practice clear communication, giving feedback, and handling typical reactions to change. They apply these skills in short role-play exercises based on workplace situations.

Module 7: Personal Future Skills

Learners reflect on their own strengths, learning habits, and areas for development. They set goals for improving self-organisation, adaptability, and continuous learning in their vocational field.

Workplace Innovation & Future Skills Training Program (EQF 3-4)

Objective

This training program primarily aims to achieve the following overarching goals:

- a) Significantly increase the attractiveness of vocational education and contribute to addressing the shortage of skilled workers.
- b) Raise qualification levels at all stages and design competence development according to both the individual needs of participants and the requirements of SMEs.
- c) Promote workplace innovation comprehensively during vocational training and provide all young people with the relevant individual competencies.

Target Group

Vocational education learners (EQF level 3-4) across all trades, especially in SME contexts. This program provides additional qualifications in innovation and transversal skills to complement trade-specific training. Each module is designed for flexible delivery (1-3 days) and can be adapted to different sectors.

Design

The design of this training program follows Bloom’s taxonomy to ensure a structured progression from basic understanding toward higher-order cognitive and practical competences. This progression aligns directly with the requirements of EQF levels 3 and 4, which define the expected *knowledge, skills, and responsibilities/autonomy* of learners in initial vocational training.

At EQF level 3, learners are expected to demonstrate

- ✓ knowledge: factual knowledge in a field of work or study,
- ✓ skills: the ability to carry out tasks and solve routine problems using basic methods and tools,
- ✓ responsibility and autonomy: the ability to take responsibility for completing assigned tasks and adapt their behaviour to circumstances.

At EQF level 4, learners are required to show

- ✓ knowledge: broad factual and theoretical knowledge within a field of work or study,
- ✓ skills: the ability to solve more complex, non-routine problems and interpret available information,

- ✓ responsibility and autonomy: the ability to self-manage within guidelines, supervise others where appropriate, and take responsibility for evaluating and improving work processes.

Following Bloom’s taxonomy, each module supports learners in progressing through increasingly complex learning stages:

- Remembering and Understanding: learners acquire foundational knowledge of workplace innovation.
- Applying and Analysing: learners use this knowledge in authentic work tasks and examine workplace situations.
- Evaluating and Creating: learners propose solutions, make informed judgements, and design improvement ideas relevant to their training company.

Implementation

The training programs are to be delivered by vocational schools as part of the regular curriculum. Students should be encouraged to bring their results and ideas into their training companies and report back during subsequent lessons on the reactions and implementations within those companies. The delivery of the seven modules should be spread across the entire training period. In the final year of training, particular emphasis should be placed on feedback regarding workplace experiences and the workplace innovations implemented in the companies.

Program Structure

Seven modules cover key areas of workplace innovation and personal development. Trainers should tailor examples and activities to the learners’ trades (e.g. construction, hospitality, technical crafts) to ensure practical relevance. The modules encourage active learning through discussions, group work, and hands-on exercises. Small and medium enterprises (SMEs) often have limited resources, so emphasis is on cost-effective, practical approaches applicable in small workplaces.

Note on Language

The content is written in clear, simple language appropriate for learners at levels 3-4. Trainers can further simplify or translate concepts as needed. Each module includes background context (for teachers to deepen understanding and to share with students in simplified form), clear learning objectives, step-by-step guidance for teaching, interactive exercises, and assessment methods.

Module 1: Introduction to Workplace Innovation

Learning Objectives

- Define “workplace innovation” and describe its importance for employees and businesses (especially SMEs).
- Identify benefits of workplace innovation, such as improved employee engagement, work quality, and company performance.
- Give examples of workplace innovation practices (e.g. employee idea programs, team improvements, new ways of working).
- Understand the need for innovation in SMEs facing rapid changes in technology and markets.

Background Context (for Teachers & Students)

Workplace innovation means making changes in how we work to create better results and a better work environment. Unlike technical innovations (new machines or products), workplace innovation focuses on people and processes - how teams are organized, how decisions are made, and how ideas are implemented. Importantly, workplace innovation is often driven by employees at every level. In fact, one definition from European experts is:

“Workplace Innovation is the employee-led social process of mobilising new ideas to create better work”^[1].

This means workers and managers come up with ideas to improve their work processes, products, or services. The twin goals are to make work more satisfying for employees and to help the company perform better^[2]. In other words, innovation should benefit both staff (through better work conditions, more learning, etc.) and the business (through higher productivity or quality).

Workplace innovation can take many forms. Examples include participative job design, self-organized teams, continuous improvement, and giving employees a voice in decision-making^[3]. All these involve people collaborating to improve how work is done. Research shows that innovative companies need skilled workers who continuously find ways to improve products and processes (“learning by doing”)^[4]. Even technicians and front-line workers contribute to innovation by suggesting improvements or solving problems on the job.

For SMEs (small and medium-sized enterprises), workplace innovation is especially vital. SMEs often cannot invest heavily in R&D, so improving workplace practices can be a key competitive advantage. As initiatives like WIN4SMEs or EUWIN noted *“Workplace innovation is vital for bolstering the success and competitiveness of SMEs. It enhances employee engagement, satisfaction, and agility while maximizing the potential of the labour force.”*^[5] In short, when a small company empowers its people to innovate in daily work, it becomes more adaptable and resilient. SMEs that promote an innovative, adaptive culture are better able to handle changes in technology or customer demand^[5].

Why now? Today’s work environment is changing fast - new technologies, globalization, and unexpected challenges (like pandemics) mean that businesses must adapt quickly. This module will help learners see that innovation is not just about significant inventions; it is also about everyday improvements and ideas that make the workplace better. By engaging in workplace innovation, employees feel more involved and valued, and businesses gain better results. In fact, major European initiatives have recognized workplace innovation as a way to create “good jobs” and improve company performance simultaneously[6][7].

Trainer Instructions for Delivery

1. Introduce the Concept (Lecture/Discussion): Define *workplace innovation* in simple terms. You might start by asking students for words they associate with “innovation at work” (e.g. “new ideas”, “improvement”, “teamwork”). Then clarify the definition. Highlight that it’s not only top management’s job - but every worker can also contribute ideas. Use real-life examples to make it concrete (see below). Keep this interactive by inviting students to share any improvements they’ve seen at a part-time job, internship, or school workshop.
2. Key points to cover: Workplace innovation involves everyone’s ideas, aims to make work better for employees *and* more effective for the company. It includes things like teams finding better ways to organize tasks, or employees suggesting changes to improve safety, quality, or customer service. Emphasize the benefit to employees (more say in their work, learning new skills) and employers (higher productivity, less waste, etc.)[8][3].
3. Use Case Studies or Stories: Share one or two short case examples of workplace innovation in action. For instance:
4. Arginta Engineering (Lithuania) - Explain how this manufacturing SME involved its workers in improving processes and saw significant gains in engagement and product quality[9]. (There is a Euronews video from 2015 about Arginta’s workplace innovation initiative, which showed employees contributing ideas at all levels.)
5. The UK Met Office - A story of a group of employees in Britain’s weather agency who proactively started an innovation group, with management support, to change their workplace culture[10]. This shows both top-down and bottom-up approaches: in one case management initiated changes, in the other, employees did - but both succeeded with teamwork and support.

6. After each example, ask learners: *“What did the company do to encourage innovation? How did the employees contribute?”* Summarize that management support and employee involvement were key in both cases - management needs to trust and back employees’ ideas, and employees need to actively participate^[11].
7. Class Brainstorm: On a flipchart or board, have a brainstorming session: *“What areas in a workplace can we innovate or improve?”* Guide them to think broadly - e.g., work processes (how work is done), workplace organization (team structure, schedules), communication (sharing ideas, meetings), technology use, health & safety, customer service, etc. Encourage *all ideas* (no matter how small). This shows that innovation isn’t only about new products - it can be daily continuous improvements. Tie this to the concept of continuous improvement (Kaizen) - small ongoing changes can add up.
8. Small Group Activity - Identify & Propose an Improvement: Divide class into small groups (3-5 students). Give each group a simple workplace scenario related to their trade (or use their actual workplace if they are apprentices). Examples: a bakery kitchen, an auto-repair workshop, a hotel front desk, a construction site team, etc. Provide a short description of current work practices in that scenario. Each group must identify one aspect that could be improved through a new idea or different approach (e.g. reducing waiting time for customers, making a task safer, improving teamwork on a project). They should discuss and write down:
9. The *current situation/problem* (e.g. “tools are disorganized, causing delays in finding them”).
10. Their *innovative idea* to improve it (e.g. “introduce a tool checklist and shadow board for tool storage”).
11. *Who* would need to be involved (e.g. “all team members agree on organizing tools and maintaining the board”).
12. *Expected benefit* (e.g. “save time each day, less frustration, finish jobs faster”). After 15-20 minutes, have groups present their improvement idea briefly. Applaud their creative efforts. Emphasize that no matter the trade, there are always things to improve, and frontline workers often have the best insights into practical solutions.

13. Wrap-Up Discussion: Reiterate that workplace innovation is a continuous *process*, not a one-time project[7][12]. It requires a mindset of curiosity and willingness to change. Pose a reflective question: *“How would you feel if your boss asked for your ideas to improve the job? Would you be more motivated?”* Most will say yes - underline that this is why companies are starting to care about workplace innovation. When employees are engaged, they *“spot problems early, bring forward ideas, and support change instead of resisting it”*[13]. It creates a positive cycle: engaged employees drive innovation, and successful innovation further engages employees.

Practical Exercises and Group Activities

- Brainstorm Buzz Groups: As described above, students practice identifying improvement opportunities in a given work scenario. This builds their observation and problem-solving skills.
- Innovation Bingo (Optional Energizer): Prepare a bingo card of innovation-related keywords (e.g. “idea”, “team”, “improve”, “experiment”, “new”, “safety”, “customer”, etc.). After the main lesson, give students 10 minutes to mingle and find examples or definitions for the terms from each other or the lesson. This is a fun review of key concepts.
- Idea Box Exercise: If possible, set up a mock “idea box” (physical or digital). Have each student write anonymously one suggestion to improve *some aspect of this classroom or workshop* (e.g. “have a 5-minute stretch break each hour to improve focus”). Collect and read a few aloud, discussing how even small ideas can make a difference. This simulates a common workplace innovation tool (the suggestion box) and stresses the importance of giving feedback.
- Video Reflection: If technology allows, show a short video (2-3 minutes) of a company practicing workplace innovation (like the Arginta Engineering piece or a local example). Then discuss: *What did employees do? How did it help the company?* This visual element can inspire learners and make the concept more tangible.

Assessment Methods

- ✓ Quiz on Key Concepts: A short quiz can check understanding of basic definitions and benefits. For example, multiple-choice or true/false questions:
- ✓ “Workplace innovation is only about new technology.” (False - it’s also about work practices and employee ideas)

- ✓ “Who typically leads workplace innovation initiatives? a) Only managers b) Only external experts c) Employees at all levels can contribute.” (Correct: c)
- ✓ “Name one benefit of workplace innovation for employees.” (e.g. increased job satisfaction or involvement). You can include a question asking for one example of workplace innovation the student learned or can think of.
- ✓ Group Presentation of Improvement Idea: Evaluate the small group exercise where they proposed an improvement. You can grade it as a simple pass/fail or give qualitative feedback on how practical and well-explained their idea was. The focus is on participation and creative thinking, not finding a “perfect” solution.
- ✓ Class Participation and Reflection: Since this module is introductory, assessment can be informal. Use a checklist during discussions: did the student contribute an idea or question? You could also ask for a one-paragraph reflection as homework: “What aspect of workplace innovation do you find most interesting or useful for your future job, and why?” This checks their understanding and personal engagement.
- ✓ Worksheet: Prepare a simple one-page worksheet titled “Workplace Innovation Summary.” It could have fill-in-the-blanks or short answer sections to reinforce learning:
- ✓ Definition of workplace innovation in my own words.
- ✓ Two benefits of workplace innovation (one for employees, one for company).
- ✓ One example of workplace innovation (from case study or personal experience).
- ✓ My idea to improve something in a workplace (a quick thought to encourage transfer of learning). Students can complete this individually as an exit ticket. Review their answers to gauge understanding.

(Printable worksheets:) Module 1 Worksheet can be printed as a handout for the above exercise. It doubles as a study note sheet for students.

Module 2: Participatory Problem Solving and Teamwork

Learning Objectives

- Explain the value of teamwork in solving workplace problems and driving innovation.
- Describe participatory problem-solving - what it means to involve all team members in finding solutions.
- Apply basic problem-solving tools in a group (e.g. brainstorming, root cause analysis with “5 Whys”).
- Demonstrate effective team collaboration through group exercises, showing skills like active listening, idea sharing, and consensus-building.
- Recognize common teamwork challenges (like communication issues or conflict) and discuss strategies to overcome them.

Background Context (for Teachers & Students)

Innovation thrives in workplaces where employees actively participate in problem-solving. “Participatory problem solving” means that instead of one boss dictating solutions, the team members who do the work every day get involved in finding better ways. This approach is rooted in respect for workers’ knowledge and encourages ownership of changes. As an innovation expert put it, engaging employees from the start is key: *“Involve employees in shaping the innovation process, not just reacting to it. Early input builds trust and creates a sense of ownership over the outcome.”*^[14]. In practical terms, when a team faces a challenge - say a recurring mistake in production or a delay in service - they come together to analyze why it’s happening and propose ideas to fix it. Everyone’s viewpoint is valued.

Effective teamwork and open communication are crucial for innovation. Many improvements in SMEs come from small teams brainstorming together or an employee suggesting a fix to a problem they noticed. High employee involvement has been linked to better company performance and successful innovation^[6]. When people feel they are part of the solution, they are more likely to support changes rather than resist them. Research on innovation shows that engaged teams will “spot problems early, bring forward grounded ideas and support change instead of resisting it”^[13] - exactly what companies need to stay competitive. On the other hand, if workers feel unheard, they may resist new initiatives or do things “the old way,” undermining improvements.

Teamwork skills like clear communication, active listening, respecting diverse ideas, and conflict resolution form the foundation of participatory problem-solving. For vocational students, learning to work in a team is as important as technical skills - almost every trade involves cooperating with others on the job. Employers highly value workers who can collaborate effectively and solve issues together. In fact, *teamwork* and *problem-solving* are considered core transversal skills (transferable across jobs) in modern apprenticeships[15].

In this module, learners practice working in groups to address a mock workplace problem. They will see that each member can have a piece of the puzzle - one may identify the root cause, another may have a creative idea to fix it, and another might foresee a challenge with the idea. By pooling their knowledge, the team can find a better solution than one person alone. This reflects common approaches in industry: for example, quality circles (small groups who meet regularly to discuss and solve work-quality issues) are a classic participatory tool. Similarly, many companies use continuous improvement meetings (e.g. daily 5-minute team huddles) to surface minor issues and solve them collectively.

Also, highlight the link to workplace innovation from Module 1: participatory problem-solving is *how* many innovations are implemented. Technology or new equipment alone won't work if people don't adapt processes around them. As noted in a European study, *“Technological innovation in the workplace is likely to fail, or fall short, unless it is combined with organisational innovation - that means high employee involvement, creation of ‘good jobs’ (with empowerment and development opportunities), and recognition that learning on the job is as important as formal training.”*[6]. In short, human factors matter. Team-based problem solving is an example of organizational innovation that makes technical changes successful.

Trainer Instructions for Delivery

1. Icebreaker - Team Puzzle: To warm up, do a quick teamwork exercise. For example, give a simple puzzle or task that requires cooperation: assemble a small jigsaw puzzle without talking, or have each student draw part of a picture that connects with others. After 5 minutes, discuss: *What was easy or hard about working together?* This primes them to think about teamwork dynamics (communication, coordination).

2. Introduce Participatory Problem Solving: Present a short interactive lecture. Define *participatory problem solving* as “when everyone in a team is involved in finding and implementing solutions to a problem.” Contrast it with a top-down approach where only a manager decides solutions. Ask: “Why might a team-based approach be better?” (Expected answers: more ideas, people on the ground know the details, more buy-in so solution is actually used, etc.) Use an example from a familiar context - e.g., in a restaurant kitchen, if there’s a delay in food service, the chef, waitstaff, and cooks might meet to discuss causes and improvements (rather than the manager alone guessing the issue). Emphasize trust and ownership: when workers are trusted to help solve issues, they feel more responsible for making the solution succeed^[14].
3. Key Roles in a Team: Explain that in teamwork, different members may take on different roles (sometimes naturally). For instance, roles like facilitator (leader) who keeps the group on track, time-keeper, note-taker, or idea generator. In a good team, everyone contributes in their own way (one might be creative, another detail-oriented, etc.). It’s important to respect each role and contribution - all are needed to solve complex problems.
4. Teach a Simple Problem-Solving Method: Introduce a basic structured approach:
5. Define the problem clearly. (What is happening vs. what should be happening?)
6. Find the root cause. A tool here is the “5 Whys” - ask “why?” repeatedly to dig deeper. For example: *Machine is frequently breaking down - Why? Because maintenance is not done - Why? Because we don’t have a schedule - Why? Because...* and so on until a core cause is found. Demonstrate this with a quick fun example with the class.
7. Brainstorm solutions together. During brainstorming, all ideas are welcome - no judging initially. Use flipchart or sticky notes, and encourage creativity.
8. Choose the best solution by discussion and consensus (consider impact and feasibility). Sometimes combining ideas works best.
9. Plan implementation - who will do what, and how will you know it’s working (set a measure or indicator if possible). This method can be remembered as a cycle: Problem -> Cause -> Ideas -> Action (similar to PDCA - Plan, Do, Check, Act cycle - but keep it simple). Write these steps on board as you explain.

10. Group Activity - Solve a Simulated Workplace Problem:
11. Divide students into small teams (4-6 people). Give each team a written scenario of a workplace problem relevant to their field. For example: *“In an auto workshop, customers complain jobs take too long.”* or *“In a bakery, too much bread is left unsold each day (waste issue).”* or *“On a construction site, there have been a few minor accidents in one month.”* Provide a few details to set the scene (but not the cause or solution).
12. Equip each team with a Problem Solving Worksheet (printable template) that guides them through the steps: Problem Description -> Possible Causes -> Proposed Solutions -> Chosen Solution -> Rationale. Encourage them to assign roles (who will lead discussion, who will write, etc.). Give them ~20-30 minutes to discuss and fill out the sheet. Circulate to coach as needed - ensure they identify at least one root cause and one solution. Remind them to practice good team behaviors: let everyone speak, listen to each other, and build on ideas.
13. Afterward, have each team briefly present their problem and solution. For instance: *“We tackled the slow service issue in the auto shop. We think a root cause is disorganized scheduling - mechanics sometimes get double-booked (why? because there’s no clear booking system). Our solution: implement a simple scheduling board and limit number of jobs per mechanic per day, plus a 15-min buffer between jobs for cleanup. We chose this because it’s low-cost and easy to try, and we expect waiting time for customers will drop.”*
14. As each team presents, encourage the class to ask one question or give one positive comment. Summarize each with praise and highlight a key point (e.g. *“Great how you used the 5 Whys”* or *“Good team effort - I can see everyone had a part in the solution.”*). This presentation not only assesses their learning but also allows peer learning (they hear problems/solutions from other sectors).
15. Discussion - Teamwork Reflections: Lead a debrief: *“What made your team work well? Any challenges?”* Typical responses might be: one person dominated, or conversely, everyone shared ideas freely; maybe they got stuck on one idea, etc. Use these to talk about common teamwork challenges:
16. Communication issues: Did everyone understand the problem the same way? Sometimes miscommunication can send teams in circles.

17. Conflicts or differing opinions: If two members disagreed on the best solution, how did they resolve it? Teach that some conflict of ideas is normal and even healthy in problem-solving - it means people care. The key is to keep it respectful and focused on facts (“Let’s look at the pros/cons”) rather than personal.
18. Participation imbalances: Was anyone quiet? Perhaps encourage thoughts from quieter members - sometimes they have ideas not heard. As a team, learn to draw out everyone’s input.
19. Emphasize that effective teams practice *open communication, trust, and shared leadership*. Everyone should feel they can speak up. This environment is what leads to innovation - when people feel safe to suggest even “odd” ideas, you sometimes get breakthroughs. (This links to the concept of psychological safety - you can mention it in simple terms: team members shouldn’t fear ridicule or punishment for speaking up.)
20. Link to Real Workplaces: Conclude by connecting this exercise to real life. Many companies implement idea-sharing and team problem-solving formally. Some examples:
21. Kaizen teams in manufacturing continuously find ways to reduce waste or improve quality.
22. Toolbox talks in trades like construction: brief team meetings to address safety issues or plan the day collectively.
23. Agile project stand-ups in IT or design, where each team member shares progress and obstacles, and the team problem-solves daily. These practices show that participatory problem-solving is widely used because it works. It leads to an “*empowered workforce actively engaged in improving all aspects of the business*”^[16], which benefits the company and makes work more rewarding. Remind learners that as future employees (or entrepreneurs), developing these teamwork and problem-solving skills will make them valued team members. It’s also a future skill: critical thinking, problem solving, and teamwork are high on the list of skills needed in the modern labor market^[15].

Practical Exercises and Group Activities

- Team Problem-Solving Simulation: (Core activity described above) - small teams work on a realistic workplace problem using a structured method. This is the centerpiece exercise for this module.

- **Brainwriting for Shy Groups:** If verbal brainstorming is tough (sometimes learners are shy in speaking), try “brainwriting.” Each student writes 1-2 ideas for solving the problem on sticky notes or paper. Then the team reviews all ideas together. This ensures everyone contributes. It can be done as part of the above simulation.
- **Marshmallow Challenge (optional fun exercise):** Build teamwork and creativity by giving groups 20 sticks of spaghetti, one marshmallow, tape, and string. Challenge: build the tallest free-standing tower that can hold the marshmallow on top, in 10 minutes. Debrief with what teamwork tactics worked or failed. (Though not directly about workplace issues, it’s a quick way to illustrate planning, prototyping, and group roles under time pressure. It lightens the session and teaches collaboration.)
- **Role-play a Team Meeting:** Select a few students to simulate a short team meeting addressing a minor workplace issue (you can use a scenario or perhaps an issue in the classroom like “the class is always late returning from break”). One acts as the team leader, others as team members. Have them demonstrate good practices: stating the problem, inviting ideas, summarizing. Then ask observers to give feedback - did everyone participate, was the goal clear, etc.? This helps reinforce effective communication behaviors.
- **Peer Evaluation Activity:** After the main exercise, you can have team members fill a quick peer feedback form (just a few prompts: “One thing ____ did well in our team:” and “One thing I learned from my team today:”). This fosters reflection on teamwork and personal contribution.

Assessment Methods

Observation Checklist: As students engage in the team problem-solving exercise, observe and note their collaboration skills. Create a simple checklist for each team: Did they identify a clear problem? Did they use a “why” analysis for causes? Did each member contribute (even if some more than others)? Did they come to an agreement on a solution? Use this to provide constructive feedback. You might score teamwork on aspects like communication, cooperation, and problem-solving approach. For example: 1 = needs improvement, 2 = satisfactory, 3 = excellent - on criteria such as “all members participated” or “followed problem-solving steps.”

Team Presentation Evaluation: Assess the solution presentations on both content and teamwork:

Content: Did they identify a plausible root cause and solution? Is the solution explained clearly with expected benefits?

Teamwork: More qualitatively, note if more than one person spoke (a good sign) and if they responded well to questions. Each team could get a group grade or recognition (like “Best root-cause analysis award” or “Most creative solution award”) to keep it fun and motivational rather than overly competitive.

Quiz or Written Test: Include questions about the concepts in a test. E.g. define participatory problem-solving, list two benefits of involving employees in decisions (expected answers: builds ownership/trust^[14], more ideas, faster problem detection^[13], etc.), or scenario-based questions like “How would you handle a situation where two team members disagree on a solution?” to test understanding of conflict resolution.

Reflection Paper: Have each student write a short reflection (5-10 sentences) on *“What did I learn about working in a team to solve problems? Give an example from the activity.”* This personal reflection can reveal insights (e.g., “I learned that listening is important because at first our team missed a good idea from a quiet member.”). Assess these for thoughtfulness and understanding rather than language perfection.

Worksheet: A Team Problem-Solving worksheet (as used in the activity) can also be collected for assessment. Review if they adequately filled each section (problem, cause, solution, etc.). This shows their grasp of the structured approach.

(Printable materials:) Provide the Problem Solving Template (table format with prompts for problem, causes, solutions, etc.) and an optional Teamwork Self-Assessment where students rate their own contributions and what they can improve (for self-reflection). These can be included in an appendix for trainers to copy.

Module 3: Digital Tools for Innovation

Learning Objectives

- Recognize the role of digital tools in modern workplaces and innovation processes.
- Identify common digital tools that can improve collaboration, productivity, and creativity (e.g. communication apps, project management software, data analysis tools).
- Understand basic digital skills needed across trades (online communication, using cloud services, basic cybersecurity and data privacy habits).
- Apply a specific digital tool in a simple task (for example, use an online collaboration platform or a digital design tool in a classroom exercise).
- Appreciate the importance of digitalization for SMEs and how adopting digital tools can make a small business more efficient and competitive.

Background Context (for Teachers & Students)

We live in a digital age, and workplaces are increasingly using digital technologies for everything from communication to manufacturing. For vocational learners in any trade, being comfortable with digital tools is now a key skill. Digital tools for innovation refer to software or technology that helps people work smarter, share ideas, and implement improvements. These tools can enable new ways of doing business (think of artisans selling online, or construction workers using tablet apps for plans). Even in traditional trades, digitalization is making an impact - for example, a plumber might use a smartphone app to manage appointments, or a mechanic uses computer diagnostics for cars. Being open to learning new tools means you can help your workplace innovate and stay competitive.

For context, governments and organizations across Europe have been training SME employees in digital skills because it's seen as essential. In one EU project in Latvia, thousands of SME workers were trained in topics like cloud services, online collaboration, digital marketing, electronic document management, and digital design tools to boost productivity^[17]. The results showed that such training significantly improved these businesses' competitiveness, and participants highly recommended it^[18]. The message is clear: digital skills are not optional; they are necessary for growth in nearly every industry.

What kinds of digital tools are we talking about? We can group them into a few categories relevant to most workplaces: - Communication and Collaboration Tools: Email is basic, but now we also have chat apps (e.g. Slack, Microsoft Teams), video conferencing (Zoom, Teams), and collaborative online documents (Google Docs, Office 365) where multiple people can edit simultaneously. These help teams (even small ones) share information quickly and work together, whether in the same office or remotely. In an SME, using a free tool like Google Drive to share files or Trello to track tasks can significantly improve coordination without considerable cost. - Productivity and Process Tools: This includes things like project management software (to plan and track work), scheduling or booking systems, digital calendars, and task management apps. For example, a small repair shop might use an online calendar for client appointments instead of a paper book - reducing double bookings and allowing everyone to see the schedule in real time. There are also tools to manage inventory, handle invoices, or track time spent on jobs - many tailored for small businesses. - Digital Design and Manufacturing Tools: Depending on the trade, this could be CAD (computer-aided design) software for technicians, graphic design tools for marketing or creatives, or even CNC machines and 3D printers for production. Learning the basics of relevant design software can open new innovation possibilities - e.g., a carpenter who knows how to use a simple CAD program can prototype furniture designs more quickly. - Data and Analysis Tools: Even small businesses generate data (sales, customer feedback, production numbers). Basic tools like spreadsheets (Excel or Google Sheets) are crucial for analyzing data. There are also user-friendly data visualization or survey tools that SMEs can use to gather and learn from data (e.g. using a free online survey to get customer input on a new idea). - Online Presence and Marketing Tools: Innovating isn't just internal - reaching customers in new ways is part of innovation. Tools for creating a website or social media page, digital marketing (Facebook/Instagram for business, etc.), and online selling platforms are valuable. A learner with some knowledge of these can help even a tiny family business expand their reach.

We also must mention digital safety and etiquette: As students become more adept with tools, they should learn basic cybersecurity habits (using strong passwords, being cautious with suspicious emails) and data protection principles (don't share private customer data insecurely). Additionally, the *mindset* of adapting to new technology is important. The specific tools will evolve, but if you know *how to learn* a new app or device, you'll stay relevant.

For EQF 3-4 learners, we aim to demystify these tools and show that digital innovation is not just for IT specialists. It's about choosing and using the right tool to make your work better. SMEs often have budget constraints, but many digital tools have free versions or affordable options. A slight improvement like using a free cloud storage instead of physical paperwork can save time and reduce errors.

By the end of this module, learners should feel more confident in exploring digital solutions in their work. They should appreciate that digitalization can spark innovation - for instance, moving a manual process to an app can eliminate errors and free up time for more creative tasks. As noted in policy circles, equipping workers with broad digital skills is crucial for the future; it “introduces the latest trends in digitalization, provides tools for business/process management and improves customer communication,” which are *essential for the competitiveness of small businesses*^{[17][18]}.

Trainer Instructions for Delivery

1. Intro Discussion - Digital Tools in Daily Life: Start by asking students what digital tools or apps they use in daily life. Many will mention social media, messaging apps, maybe online banking or shopping. List a few on the board. Then bridge to work life: “Which of these or other digital tools might also be useful on the job?” For example, WhatsApp or Messenger groups might be used by a team for quick communication; YouTube tutorials for learning a repair technique; a calendar app for scheduling clients. This activates their prior knowledge and shows they likely already have some digital skills that transfer to work.
2. Show and Tell - Common Workplace Apps: Prepare a short presentation or live demo of a few common digital tools:
3. Collaboration: Open a shared document (Google Doc or Office 365) on the projector and have one or two students join from their phone/laptop to edit simultaneously (if feasible). This wows them that multiple people can contribute at once. Explain how teams use this for co-authoring reports or keeping a shared log.
4. Project or Task Board: Show a screenshot or demo of a simple Kanban board (like Trello or Microsoft Planner) with “To Do / Doing / Done” columns. Explain this visual way of tracking tasks - many trades can use it (e.g. tracking stages of a job). Perhaps create a sample board for “Planning a company event” or “Weekly tasks in a workshop” to illustrate.
5. Communication: If not too technically challenging, demonstrate how a video meeting works (e.g., start a Zoom/Teams meeting and show features briefly). Or simply discuss how chat groups help when quick answers are needed - but also the need for discipline (not spamming at off-hours, etc.).

6. Design/Technical Tool: Tailor to the student group: For mechanics or builders, show a 3D model or diagram tool; for business or service trades, maybe an online form or a simple design in Canva (a free graphic design tool) for making a flyer. Keep it basic - the goal is awareness, not mastery in one session.
7. Emphasize: *“These tools might seem a bit new, but they can save a lot of time and errors.”* Also note that learning new tools is a skill in itself - encourage curiosity. If you don’t know how an app works, you can often find a tutorial video or help menu.
8. Hands-on Practice: Depending on resources (computers or smartphones available), do a mini practical exercise:
9. Collaboration Exercise: Break into small groups (2-3). If devices and internet are available, have each group write a few lines in a shared online document or slide deck (set it up beforehand, one per group, or use a platform like Padlet or Jamboard as a shared canvas). Give a fun prompt related to innovation, e.g. “List 3 ideas to improve our classroom or workshop using digital tools.” The key is they experience editing something together live. If devices are not available, simulate by having them collectively fill out a template on paper for comparison, then show how it could be done online.
10. QR Code or App Demo: You can generate a QR code to a simple online resource (like a safety checklist on Google Forms) and have them scan it with their phones to illustrate how even a plumbing company might use QR codes on equipment for manuals, etc.
11. Digital scavenger hunt: If there are PCs, have them find certain info on a website (like “find the contact email on company X’s site”) to practice navigation - but ensure it’s guided and not too open-ended.
12. Case Study - SME Goes Digital: Share a short success story of a small business that innovated through digital tools:
13. For example, a local craftsman who started selling via an online marketplace and used digital inventory tracking to keep up with orders.
14. Or a case where a trades company introduced a tablet-based inspection checklist (replacing paper) and cut errors by 50%.

15. If you have none at hand, use a generalized narrative: “Imagine a small garage that adopted an online booking system - customers can book slots on a website instead of calling. As a result, bookings went up and no-shows went down because customers get automatic reminders.” Ask students how that digital change improved things (likely answers: convenience, time saved, more business).
16. Reinforce that digital innovation doesn’t require one to be an IT expert. It’s often about using available tools cleverly. Many are plug-and-play or have templates for beginners.
17. Group Brainstorm - Tools for Trades: On a flipchart, write 3 column headers: *“Communication”, “Efficiency”, “Creativity.”* Now ask the class to think of any digital tool or tech under each that could help at work:
18. Communication: e.g. WhatsApp, Email, Teams, Zoom, walkie-talkie apps, etc.
19. Efficiency: e.g. barcode scanners, digital timers, scheduling apps, accounting software (like a digital cash register or point-of-sale app).
20. Creativity/Innovation: e.g. design software, simulation apps (some trades have simulators or AR/VR for training), even simply using Google to search for new ideas or solutions. As they call out items, fill them in. Add any key ones they miss. This visual map shows the breadth of digital tools. If some students have experience with specific tools (maybe someone used a CNC machine, or an inventory app in a part-time job), invite them to share that experience briefly.
21. Addressing Fears: Some learners may feel less confident with tech (“I’m not good with computers”). Encourage them: basic usage can be learned step by step. Remind them that most tools today are designed to be user-friendly because companies know not everyone is a techie. Also, troubleshooting is part of the process - not to be discouraged by initial mistakes. Perhaps share a personal anecdote of a digital mishap and how you solved it, to humanize the learning curve.
22. Security and Etiquette Mini-Talk: Before closing, spend a few minutes on safe and responsible use:
23. Protect personal and company data: don’t share passwords, beware of phishing (explain simply: strange emails asking for info or with links - when in doubt, don’t click or ask someone).

24. Follow workplace IT policies: e.g. some companies limit use of personal messaging during work, or require backups of files. These exist to keep data safe and maintain professionalism.
25. Digital etiquette: For instance, in chats or emails be respectful, use clear language (and proper tone with customers). In video meetings, know how to mute/unmute, etc.
26. These might sound like common sense, but they are part of digital skills too.
27. Forward Look - Lifelong Learning: Conclude by highlighting that digital tools evolve quickly. The best skill they can take away is the ability to learn new tools. Encourage them to be the person in their company who's not afraid to try a new app or suggest a digital solution - it could make them a key innovator. Many employers appreciate when young employees bring digital know-how (for example, setting up a social media page for a small bakery could attract new customers, something the older owner might not know how to do). Summarize that adopting digital tools can lead to innovating how work is done, offering huge advantages in efficiency and even opening up new business opportunities^[18].

Practical Exercises and Group Activities

- Digital Tool Demos: As described, hands-on mini exercises with collaboration docs or task boards give experiential learning.
- Explore an App in Pairs: Provide a list of free apps/web tools (or screenshots if internet is an issue). Assign each pair a tool to quickly research (e.g., “What does Slack do? How might it help a team?” or “Find one feature of Excel that could help manage inventory.”). Then have each pair share one cool thing they found. This teaches learners how to learn about tools on their own.
- Mobile App Tour: If all students have smartphones, have them open an app that could be useful (for example, Google Keep for notes or Microsoft To-Do for task lists). Give them 5 minutes to add a sample note or task (“Remind me to calibrate machine on Friday”). Little exercises like these build confidence and show immediate utility.
- Digital Quiz Game: Use an online quiz platform (like Kahoot! or Quizizz) to run a quiz about digital tools and concepts covered. This itself is a demonstration of a digital engagement tool. Include practical questions (e.g., identify an icon or match a tool to its function). Students usually enjoy the gamified aspect.

- Plan a Digital Upgrade: Split groups by trade (if applicable) and ask each to think of one process in their trade training that is currently manual or inefficient, then propose a digital tool to improve it. For example, for electricians: using a tablet app for inspections instead of paper forms; for cooks: an app to track inventory so they know when to order ingredients. Have groups present their “digital upgrade” idea. This combines creativity and sector-specific thinking.
- Invite a Guest or Video: If possible, have a short talk (in person or via video) from a young professional or IT tutor about how they introduced a simple digital innovation at work. Alternatively, find a 2-minute YouTube clip of “small business digital transformation” to inspire (ensure it’s understandable for your learners). This external voice can reinforce the message that even small changes (like using an online payment system) can be innovative for a business.

Assessment Methods

- ✓ Practical Task Evaluation: If students performed a hands-on task (like editing a shared document or creating a simple digital artifact), assess their ability to follow the instructions and complete it. This can be a completion grade (did they manage to do it?) rather than detailed technical skill grading.
- ✓ Quiz/Test on Concepts: Include a section in a test about digital tools. Example questions:
- ✓ Match tool to purpose (e.g. “Trello” -> “Task tracking board”, “Zoom” -> “Video meetings”).
- ✓ Why questions: “Why might a small business use cloud storage instead of only saving files on one computer?” (Expected: accessible anywhere, backup, easier sharing).
- ✓ Safety question: “What is one thing you should do to stay safe online at work?” (Expected: e.g. use strong passwords, don’t open suspicious emails, log out of accounts, etc.).
- ✓ Short answer: “Give an example of a digital tool that could help a team collaborate and explain how.” (This tests application of knowledge).

- ✓ **Project Assignment:** For a more in-depth assessment (if time and curriculum allow), you could assign a mini-project: Each student (or pair) chooses a particular digital tool (from a provided list) and prepares a one-page summary or poster of how it works and how it could benefit their future workplace. They then present it briefly. This assesses research and understanding. For EQF 3-4, ensure they have guidance and perhaps a template (like “Tool name, What it does, Screenshot, Pros, Cons, How I would use it in [trade]”).
- ✓ **Participation and Confidence:** Observe and note students’ willingness to engage with the tech demonstrations. Sometimes an assessment here is more feedback-based - e.g., “I noticed you were hesitant with the computer at first but by the end you created a document - well done stepping outside your comfort zone.” This personal encouragement can be valuable to those less confident.
- ✓ **Homework/Worksheet:** Provide a take-home worksheet or quiz focusing on identifying digital solutions. For example, describe three short scenarios and ask the student to suggest a digital tool or approach to improve each. Sample scenario: *“A small carpentry business is losing track of customer orders written on paper notes.”* An answer could be, *“Use a simple online spreadsheet or order management app to record all orders, so it’s organized and backed up”*. Evaluate their answers for logic and understanding of how digital tools can be applied.

(Materials:) If needed, attach screenshots in an appendix of interfaces of suggested tools (to avoid relying on live internet). A Glossary of Digital Terms (defining cloud, spreadsheet, etc. in simple terms) can be a helpful handout or reference in the manual, supporting lower-level learners.

Module 4: Sustainability and Social Responsibility at Work

Learning Objectives

- Understand the concept of sustainability in a workplace context (environmental, social, and economic aspects) and why it matters.
- Identify practices for environmental sustainability relevant to their trade (e.g. reducing waste, saving energy, recycling materials).
- Recognize what social responsibility means for a business (fair labor practices, community involvement, ethical behavior).
- Assess their own workplace or training environment for areas to improve sustainability and propose simple changes.
- Develop habits and plans to perform their professional tasks in an environmentally friendly and socially responsible way (e.g. proper waste sorting, ethical customer service).

Background Context (for Teachers & Students)

Sustainability at work means doing business in a way that is good for the environment and society, not just profit. In simple terms, it’s “meeting our needs today without preventing future generations from meeting theirs.” For workers, this boils down to everyday actions: saving energy, minimizing waste and pollution, using resources wisely, and treating people (colleagues, customers, community) fairly. Social responsibility is often talked about as Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) - even small businesses have a role in their communities and environment.

Why include this in vocational training? Because across all trades, expectations are changing: industry and customers increasingly value green and ethical practices. Knowing how to work sustainably can make learners more employable and capable of helping their future employer improve. Many small companies are looking for ways to reduce costs through energy efficiency or to attract eco-conscious customers by being “greener.” Young workers with knowledge in this area can contribute ideas and lead by example.

European vocational programs are starting to integrate “green skills” for exactly these reasons. For instance, in Latvia a Green Skills module was developed for VET (very similar to this one) targeting EQF 3-4 students^{[19][20]}. The objective was *“to promote the learners’ ability to perform their professional activities in accordance with sustainable development of the environment, resource-saving and energy efficiency, to make environmentally friendly decisions on a daily basis.”*^[20]. This underscores that no matter the profession, from mechanic to hairdresser, one should know how to do the job in a way that reduces harm to the planet and contributes positively to society.

Key concepts to cover: - Environmental sustainability: Using resources (materials, water, energy) efficiently; reducing waste and emissions; recycling and reusing materials when possible; preventing pollution (like oil or chemical spills in a workshop, or proper ventilation to reduce air pollutants). Also, choosing greener alternatives if available (e.g. eco-friendly materials, renewable energy sources). - Social responsibility: Ensuring health and safety of employees and customers; treating co-workers with respect (no discrimination, fair wages if they become business owners or managers); engaging in the community (like a company supporting a local charity or simply being a good neighbor, not causing nuisance). Also ethical behavior - honesty with customers, sourcing materials from fair suppliers if possible, etc. For an apprentice, this could be as straightforward as following ethical guidelines of their trade (e.g., an electrician disposing of old electronics properly, or a culinary student donating unsold safe food instead of trashing it).

It can be helpful to introduce the “triple bottom line” concept in simple language: success isn’t just measured in profit, but also in impact on People, Planet, and Profit (the 3 Ps). A sustainable business tries to balance all three: - Planet (Environment): e.g., a factory installing solar panels and reducing waste water. - People (Social): e.g., a small company offering training and good working conditions, or supporting a community event. - Profit (Economic): staying financially healthy - because without profits, a business can’t sustain the other efforts. (Emphasize sustainability is not anti-profit; it’s about *responsible* profit.)

Another perspective is “think global, act local” - understanding big issues like climate change or social inequality, but taking action in your immediate work environment.

Vocational learners might wonder, “what can I really do as just one worker?” The answer: quite a lot, collectively. For example, if each person in a workshop ensures machines are turned off when not in use and waste is sorted properly, the cumulative effect is significant (lower energy bills, less landfill waste). Additionally, new regulations and standards are coming up in many industries (like requirement to handle hazardous waste properly, or energy audits for companies). Having knowledge in these areas will likely be required.

Finally, there is a creative and innovative aspect: sustainability can drive innovation. Constraints like “use less energy” can spur inventive solutions (like redesigning a process to be more efficient). Many new business ideas are born from sustainability challenges (recycling businesses, renewable energy, etc.). So instilling a sustainability mindset can also make learners more innovative.

Trainer Instructions for Delivery

1. Green Brainstorm Icebreaker: Write on board “How can a company be eco-friendly or socially responsible?”. Give students sticky notes or small scraps of paper. Ask them to write at least one idea (anything - even very simple like “recycle paper” or “don’t pollute the river”). Collect and quickly cluster the ideas on the board. Usually you’ll get things like save energy, recycle, charity, treat workers well, etc. This activity activates their existing knowledge and shows them they already know many sustainable practices. Highlight a few good examples from their notes as you transition into the topic.
2. Define Sustainability in simple terms: Present a short explanation: *“Sustainability means doing things in a way that doesn’t harm our future. In a job, this means protecting the environment and being responsible to people while doing business.”* Break it into two parts: environmental and social (with possibly a mention of economic viability).
3. For environmental, consider using a visual or analogy: e.g., show a picture of a polluted river vs. a clean river, or a huge pile of industrial waste vs. recycled materials. Discuss how industries have impacted nature and why we care (health, climate, resources for future). Vocational angle: A construction student can relate to minimizing material waste, an auto-mechanic to handling oil and batteries properly, etc.
4. For social responsibility, maybe reference something relatable: e.g., a company that supports an employee volunteering day or a local sports team. Or discuss fair treatment: *“Would you work for a company that underpays or ignores safety? Social responsibility is about not doing those bad things and actively doing good.”*
5. Relate to Students’ Trades: Go around and ask each student (or in small groups by trade) to name one environmental or social impact of their future job. Some prompting examples:
6. Electrician: handling electrical waste (like old wiring, electronics), energy efficiency in installations.

7. Hairdresser: water and electricity usage, chemicals in hair products going down the drain.
8. Mechanic: oil disposal, scrap metal recycling, worker safety around machinery.
9. Chef/Baker: food waste, sourcing local ingredients, hygienic practices (social responsibility to customers).
10. Welder: air quality (ventilation), noise (impact on community), protective gear (safety). Make a quick list on board under each trade mentioned. This personalization helps them see it's relevant to *their* work, not an abstract idea. Add any important ones they miss.
11. Introduce Good Practices: For each common area, give practical examples of what a sustainable practice looks like:
12. Waste Reduction: e.g., in an automotive workshop use reusable rags instead of disposable ones when possible; in an office, print double-sided or go paperless; in construction, measure carefully to avoid material off-cuts, and reuse off-cuts where feasible.
13. Energy Saving: turn off machines and lights when not in use (perhaps install a reminder sign or use automatic sensors); maintain equipment (a well-tuned machine uses less energy); use energy-efficient tools (like LED lights, or newer energy-star rated appliances).
14. Water Saving: fix leaks promptly, use low-flow fixtures if available, don't run water unnecessarily (relevant in plumbing, hospitality, etc.).
15. Proper Waste Management: segregate recyclables (paper, metal, plastic, glass) and hazardous waste. Explain that things like batteries, oils, chemicals should never go in regular trash - there are usually special disposal rules (give local examples if applicable, like e-waste drop off centers).
16. Social Practices: keeping the workplace safe and healthy (follow safety rules, use PPE - that's being responsible to yourself and coworkers); respect and teamwork (no bullying or harassment - a socially responsible workplace has a good culture); service quality and honesty (if something goes wrong, a responsible worker/company admits and fixes it rather than hiding it). Also, contributing to community - e.g. a bakery donating unsold bread to a shelter, or a student project planting trees in a community garden as part of a volunteering effort.

17. Optionally, mention sustainable development goals (SDGs) at a high level if you feel it's useful - but only in passing like “these ideas tie into global goals like climate action, responsible consumption, etc.” Do not overwhelm them with UN jargon; keep focus on practical actions.
18. Show Examples/Case Studies: Prepare one or two short case stories:
19. *Example 1:* A small manufacturing SME that switched to recycling most of its production scrap and cut down waste disposal costs by 30%. The boss might have also involved employees in finding energy savings, resulting in lower electricity bills. This shows sustainability can save money too (which gets attention - *profit* side of triple bottom line).
20. *Example 2:* A service business (like a hotel or salon) that adopted a community initiative - e.g., the hotel started an internship program for local youth (social responsibility) or the salon switched to cruelty-free product lines and properly disposes of chemical waste. Outcome: better reputation, customers appreciate it. If possible, use local or familiar companies which the students might know. Even a quick look-up can find something like “X company installed solar panels” or “Y workshop wins green award for recycling oil”. Alternatively, use a hypothetical but realistic scenario to illustrate. The aim is to inspire and show tangible benefits: reduced costs, improved company image, compliance with laws, and simply “feeling good about doing the right thing.”
21. Interactive Activity - Sustainability Audit: Conduct a classroom or workshop “green audit.” Give students a simple checklist of things to observe in your training facility (or a simulated workplace setting if available): Are lights/equipment left on when not used? Are recycling bins present and labeled? Is there any dripping faucet? Do we see unnecessary waste (like disposable cups instead of reusables)? Also social aspects: is the first aid kit visible? Safety signs in place? A suggestion box (employee voice)?
22. Split into small groups, each inspects a different area or aspect (energy, waste, safety, etc.) for 5-10 minutes.
23. Then have groups report one good thing they found and one area for improvement.
24. Discuss feasible fixes for the class environment - maybe implement one, like setting up a paper recycling bin or making a sign “Last one out, turn off lights.” This makes sustainability action real and empowers students to initiate change immediately in their environment.

25. Tie this to how they could do the same when they go to a workplace - politely observe and suggest improvements or at least practice good habits themselves (even if others don't).
26. Group Exercise - Plan a Green/Social Initiative: In small groups, have learners design a tiny “initiative” that an imaginary small company could do:
27. It could be environmental (e.g., “Green Week campaign: everyone cycles or carpools to work one day, company provides free lunch as reward” or “Plant a tree for every 100 products sold”).
28. Or social (e.g., “Apprentices organize a safety training day for all staff” or “Shop will sponsor local youth sports team with some profits”). Encourage creativity but also relevance to their trade or interests. Give them 15 minutes to outline: what the initiative is, who participates, and expected benefit. Then each group shares. This not only reinforces concepts but builds initiative-taking and project thinking skills.
29. Emphasize Personal Responsibility: End by reinforcing that *everyone* in a workplace contributes to sustainability. Quote if useful: *“The emerging need for green skills in the labour market called for integrating modules that cover essential competencies. ‘Green skills’ are the knowledge, abilities, values and attitudes needed to live in, develop, and support a sustainable and resource-efficient society^[21].”* For students, this means developing certain habits and attitudes now:
30. Turning off, sorting waste, being conscious of resources,
31. thinking about the community impact of their work (noise, pollution, etc.),
32. and being ready to learn new “green” methods as technology evolves (e.g., learning about electric vehicles if you're an auto mechanic, since that's the sustainable trend). Encourage them that even small actions count, and as they grow in their careers, they might lead bigger sustainability efforts. Remind them that companies are increasingly looking for workers who can help meet environmental standards and come up with improvement ideas - a chance for them to shine.

Practical Exercises and Group Activities

- Sustainability Audit (Green Walk): (Detailed above) - hands-on assessment of current environment with immediate feedback and improvement actions.

- **Waste Sorting Game:** Bring a bag of clean “waste” items (papers, a plastic bottle, banana peel (can use a picture), battery, etc.). Have volunteers sort them into categories: recyclables, compost, hazardous, landfill. Time them as a fun challenge. Then correct any mistakes (like battery goes to hazardous, etc.). This is a quick, tactile way to reinforce proper waste management.
- **Energy Challenge:** As a class, set a challenge for the week: reduce energy use in the classroom/shop by X% (if measurable) or simply ensure all devices and lights are off when not in use. Monitor and celebrate success (maybe “we saved X kWh or the lights were off every break time, well done!”). If actual measurement is not possible, make it a checklist goal.
- **Case Study Discussion:** Provide a short paragraph describing a scenario: *“The factory where Ana works dumps hot water into a nearby stream, which is legal but raises the water temperature. She is concerned about fish. What could she suggest?”* Or *“A small café throws away a lot of unsold food daily. What could they do differently?”* Have students discuss solutions in pairs, then share. This builds problem-solving oriented to sustainability. Listen for solutions like cooling water before release or reuse, donating food, offering end-of-day discounts to reduce waste, etc., and add any additional ones.
- **Role-Play - The Responsible Worker:** Do a quick role-play where one student is an employee noticing a sustainability issue (say, a colleague tossing a recyclable bottle in trash or a manager ignoring a safety hazard). Another is the colleague/manager. The first student must diplomatically raise the issue. This practices communication in potentially sensitive situations. Then discuss: what is a respectful way to suggest a greener or safer practice at work? Emphasize focusing on the benefit (“it will save money/keep us safe/help the environment”) rather than blame.
- **Community Project (if feasible):** If time and resources allow, undertake a mini project like planting a tree on school grounds, organizing a collection drive for recyclables or old electronics, or visiting a local recycling facility or eco-friendly business. Real-world engagement can be very impactful. If not possible, a virtual alternative is to watch a short video about recycling or green practices in industry and discuss.

Assessment Methods

- ✓ **Quiz on Key Concepts:** Include questions like:

- ✓ Define “sustainable development” in one sentence (student might say ensuring resources for future, etc.).
- ✓ Give two examples of sustainable practices at work (one environmental, one social).
- ✓ Multiple-choice on sorting waste or identifying what is sustainable vs not (e.g. “Which of these is NOT an environmentally sustainable practice? a) Using energy-efficient bulbs, b) Dumping chemicals into a river at night, c) Recycling metal scraps. - Obviously b).
- ✓ Short answer: “Why is it important for SMEs to be sustainable?” (Possible answers: saves cost, meets regulations, attracts customers, good for planet, etc. - expecting any reasonable one, could cite that it ensures a resilient future^[5]).
- ✓ Practical assignment: Assess the outcome of the sustainability audit activity. For example, each student could submit a checklist or a short report summarizing one finding from the audit and a recommendation. Grade on their ability to observe and suggest something concrete.
- ✓ Group initiative presentations: If groups created a green/social initiative idea, evaluate those presentations or posters. Criteria: relevance, creativity, clarity of explanation, and potential impact. This assesses understanding and the ability to apply concepts in planning an action.
- ✓ Reflection or Pledge: Ask students to write a brief reflection or even a “personal sustainability pledge.” For instance: “*One thing I will do to be more sustainable in my work or daily life is... because*” Evaluate these for sincerity and thoughtfulness. It shows if they internalized the importance (e.g., a student might write “I will always separate recyclables at work because I learned it reduces waste going to landfill and can even save the company money on waste disposal.”).
- ✓ Observation of Habits: If this class is run over days, you (the trainer) can quietly observe if students actually implement some practices (like turning off lights, using recycling bins). While this might not be a formal grade, it can be noted as positive reinforcement in their skill portfolio - “demonstrated environmentally responsible behavior during workshop.” It aligns with attitude/values assessment which is often part of competency-based learning.
- ✓ Worksheet: A possible Green Skills Worksheet to collect could include scenario-based questions and short answers:

- ✓ Scenario: “You see a coworker dump used motor oil in the general waste bin. What do you do?” (Expect: tell supervisor or advise coworker about proper disposal, etc.)
- ✓ Checklist: List 3 things you can do to save energy or reduce waste in a [student’s trade] workshop.
- ✓ True/False: e.g. “Social responsibility only applies to big companies.” (False - even small ones and individuals have it). You can mark this worksheet for correctness and completeness.

(Supplementary materials:) Provide a simple Sustainability Tips handout with bullet points summarizing best practices (perhaps divided by themes: Energy, Waste, Safety, Community). Also, possibly an Eco-Glossary explaining terms like recycle, carbon footprint, etc., if literacy level requires. If local environmental regulations are relevant (like mandatory recycling laws or safety codes), include a brief note for teacher reference to mention.

Module 5: Entrepreneurship and Intrapreneurship

Learning Objectives

- Differentiate between entrepreneurship and intrapreneurship (starting a new business vs. innovating within an existing company).
- Understand the basic steps to develop a business or project idea (opportunity recognition, planning, resources, execution).
- Identify key traits of an entrepreneurial mindset: creativity, initiative, risk-taking, resilience, problem-solving.
- Develop a simple business or innovation idea related to their trade (e.g. a new service or product) and outline it (who are the customers, what is needed to start, etc.).
- Recognize the value of entrepreneurship and intrapreneurship for personal career and for SMEs (e.g. driving growth, adapting to change).

Background Context (for Teachers & Students)

Entrepreneurship means starting your own business or venture. Think of an entrepreneur as someone who sees an opportunity (a need or a problem) and creates a solution (like a new product or service) and builds an organization around it. Intrapreneurship, on the other hand, is when someone behaves like an entrepreneur *within* an existing company - they initiate new projects, innovate processes, or launch new product lines for their employer rather than for themselves^[22]. Both require similar skills: innovation, leadership, and a willingness to take calculated risks.

Why should vocational students learn about this? First, many may not realize that they could become entrepreneurs. But *“VET students are important potential entrepreneurs as they are close to working life - each student is a potential entrepreneur.”*^[23]. They have practical skills and understand their trade’s work - sometimes that directly translates to starting a small business (like a car mechanic opening a garage, a baker starting a bakery, a hairdresser opening a salon). Even if they don’t start a business immediately, knowing the basics of entrepreneurship can help them plan for the future (maybe a few years into their career).

Second, intrapreneurship is increasingly valued by employers. SMEs especially need innovative employees who take initiative to improve things. If you work in a small company and act like an intrapreneur - coming up with new ideas, finding ways to attract customers or save money - you become very valuable to your boss. You might lead new initiatives and get more responsibility. Companies like Google famously allowed employees to spend some time on their own projects, which led to huge innovations (Gmail was created by an intrapreneur at Google)[24]. While a small family business is not Google, the principle holds: giving employees freedom to innovate can lead to improvements and new income streams. As one source notes, *“Intrapreneurship encourages innovation by allowing employees to act like entrepreneurs within a company, promoting creativity and risk-taking without the financial risks of starting a new business.”*[25].

Key topics to cover: - Basic Entrepreneurship Process: Identify opportunity -> Develop idea -> Make a business plan (how will it work, what do you need) -> Gather resources (maybe money, partners, tools) -> Launch -> Learn and adapt. We keep it simple, but students should grasp that it's not just “have an idea and make money” - planning and persistence are needed. - Essential elements of a business plan (simplified): product/service, target customers, pricing, marketing, and budgeting. We won't draft full plans here, but introduce these thinking areas. - Entrepreneurial mindset qualities: initiative (being proactive), creativity (thinking of new solutions), willingness to take responsibility and some risk (e.g., invest time/money without guarantee of success), perseverance (since not everything works first try), and also basic financial and organizational skills. Many of these overlap with skills they use in other modules like problem-solving, teamwork, communication. - Intrapreneurship in practice: how to spot improvement or new product ideas at work; how to propose an idea to your boss; taking leadership of a small project even if it's not in your job description (like implementing a new inventory system or starting a side service). - Benefits and challenges: Entrepreneurs get to be their own boss and pursue their vision, but also face risk of failure and need to handle many tasks (from finances to marketing). Intrapreneurs have the safety of a company's support and resources, but might have less autonomy than true entrepreneurs (they usually need approval for their ideas and might not get personal financial reward if the idea succeeds - though they might get promotions or bonuses). Both can be very fulfilling, creating something new.

It's also worth noting entrepreneurship is encouraged at the policy level: it's one of the EU's key competences for lifelong learning. There are even frameworks (like EntreComp) that outline entrepreneurship competence in detail (though we won't dive deep into that, just mention that the ability to turn ideas into action is widely recognized as essential). By learning entrepreneurship, students also learn a lot of transferable skills: planning, budgeting, pitching ideas, etc.

Finally, reassure students that not everyone will start a business, and that’s okay. But learning to “think like an entrepreneur” makes one more resourceful and opportunity-aware in any career. And who knows - they might spot a niche later and remember this training as a starting point.

Trainer Instructions for Delivery

1. Discussion Starter - Famous Entrepreneurs: Ask if students can name any famous entrepreneurs (local or global). They might say names like Steve Jobs, Elon Musk, or a famous chef who started a restaurant, or even the founder of a local business. List a couple of names and what businesses they started. Then point out: these people identified opportunities and were not afraid to try something new. Now, bring it closer: *“Can you think of any small businesses around here? Who started them?”* Maybe someone’s neighbor opened a car wash or a tailoring shop. Highlight that entrepreneurs are everywhere, not just tech billionaires - even the food truck owner or the two-person plumbing company are entrepreneurs. This helps demystify the term.
2. Entrepreneur vs. Intrapreneur: Define clearly:
3. An Entrepreneur is someone who creates and runs a new business venture, taking on financial risks for the hope of profit.
4. An Intrapreneur is an employee who acts like an entrepreneur within a company - they use creativity and initiative to develop something new for their employer[22]. Use a scenario to illustrate: *“Imagine you love baking. As an entrepreneur, you might open your own bakery. As an intrapreneur, if you work at a bakery chain, you might come up with a new line of pastries and convince your boss to launch it - you didn’t start the whole business, but you started a new venture inside it.”* Perhaps write on the board two columns (“Your own business” vs “In your job”) and put examples under each. Emphasize both create value and require innovation. Also mention: intrapreneurs don’t invest their own money (usually), but they also might not reap all the reward (the company does, though intrapreneurs often get recognition or promotion). Entrepreneurs risk their own capital but if successful, they get the profits/ownership.

5. Why SMEs need this: Refer back to Module 1 about innovation - entrepreneurship is how many small companies begin (someone had an idea and took the plunge), and intrapreneurship is how existing SMEs evolve (an employee's idea might become a new product line or a new market expansion). You can quote: *“Skilled workers with an entrepreneurial mindset contribute to continuous improvement and innovation in companies”*^[4]. Also mention that many VET graduates do end up starting small businesses especially in trades (like a self-employed electrician or a craft shop owner). It's good to be prepared.
6. Key Traits Brainstorm: Ask: *“What qualities do you think someone needs to start a business or drive a new idea at work?”* Write responses on board, aiming for things like: *creative, hard-working, risk-taker, leader, good planner, confident, patient, problem-solver, good with people, etc.* Fill gaps by suggesting if not mentioned. Explain each a bit:
7. *Creativity*: to come up with unique ideas or see an opportunity others don't.
8. *Initiative*: not waiting to be told what to do - entrepreneurs/intrapreneurs are self-starters.
9. *Risk-taking*: willing to venture into the unknown. But note: calculated risk - they usually research and plan to increase chances, they don't gamble blindly.
10. *Resilience*: failures or setbacks will happen (a client rejects an idea, a permit is delayed, etc.). They need to bounce back, learn, and try again.
11. *Persuasion/Communication*: they often need to convince investors, bosses, or customers that their idea is good. So being able to clearly explain and pitch the value is important.
12. *Basic financial sense*: an entrepreneur must budget and manage money; an intrapreneur might need to justify cost and benefits to the company.
13. *Team building*: entrepreneurs often start alone but then need a team as they grow. Intrapreneurs also often lead a small team or coordinate across departments to implement their idea. This sets the stage that these skills can be learned or practiced.
14. Exercise - Ideation (Coming up with a Business Idea): Make it fun - do a quick creativity exercise:

15. Option A: Random Word Brainstorm - write 3 random nouns on the board (e.g., “coffee,” “bicycle,” “window”) and challenge groups to think of a business idea that somehow involves all 3 (silly or serious). Share for laughs and creativity warm-up.
16. Option B: Problem Brainstorm - ask each student to think of one problem or need they’ve encountered in daily life or work (“It’s hard to...”, “I wish there was a ...”). Write them down. Then pick one or two and have the class suggest possible business ideas that solve it. For example, “I often miss the bus” might lead to ideas like a real-time bus tracking app, or a paid carpool service in the area. Emphasize: identifying problems is where opportunities often lie.
17. Plan a Mini-Venture (Group Activity): Now the core practical part: have students form small groups of 3-4. Each group will come up with either:
18. A hypothetical new business they could start in their trade *or*
19. A new product/service idea to introduce in an existing company (their apprenticeship workplace maybe) - i.e., intrapreneurial project. Give them a structured template or guide questions:
20. *Idea*: What is the product or service? What need does it fulfill?
21. *Customers*: Who are the target customers? (local community, certain age group, specific industry?)
22. *Uniqueness*: What’s new or better about your idea compared to others? (faster, cheaper, better quality, unique features?)
23. *Resources*: What would you need to make it happen? (Money, equipment, partners? If it’s a business, maybe how much money to set up; if it’s a project in a company, maybe need boss’s approval and some budget.)
24. *Potential challenges*: What risks or obstacles do you foresee? (Competition, cost, need skills, etc.)

25. *Success measure:* How would you know if it's succeeding? (Profit in X years, number of customers, etc.) Keep it low-pressure - it's fine if these are simple ideas. They could be realistic or somewhat imaginative. Example ideas to inspire: a carpenter might think of making custom furniture with recycled wood (entrepreneurial with eco-twist), or as an intrapreneur at a furniture factory propose a line of pet furniture. A hospitality student might imagine a themed food truck, or as an intrapreneur propose a new delivery service for their restaurant. Give them ~20-30 minutes to discuss and sketch the idea. Encourage one person to jot down the main points (provide flipchart paper or a large sheet if possible to present).
26. Group Presentations (Pitch Time): Let each group present their idea as if pitching to an investor or to the class (who can pretend to be a panel). Keep it friendly and supportive. They should cover the basics from the template. After each pitch, give positive feedback and ask a gentle question or two like “How will you market it?” or “What would you do if only a few customers came at first?” to spur their thinking. Applaud creativity and encourage them - some ideas might be quite viable! Optionally, you can have the class vote (nicely) on the most innovative idea, most likely to succeed, etc., with small prizes or just recognition. But focus on learning, not competition.
27. Debrief - Lessons Learned: Discuss what they found easy or hard about that exercise. Usually, coming up with ideas is fun, but thinking of practical details is challenging. That's exactly the point: entrepreneurs/intrapreneurs must do both - dream big *and* figure out how to execute. Summarize a few key takeaways:
28. Planning is crucial: an idea alone is just the start, planning how to make it real is the big part (we just scratched the surface of planning).
29. It's okay if not everything is answered - entrepreneurs proceed with uncertainty but try to research and fill gaps as they go.
30. Team or support: Notice in groups they collaborated - similarly, in real life entrepreneurs often have co-founders or mentors, and intrapreneurs have colleagues and bosses. One person can start an idea, but to grow, you need others on board.
31. Value of intrapreneurship: Ask: *“How would a boss likely react if an employee comes with a well-thought-out idea that could earn or save money?”* Most will say the boss would be happy (perhaps cautious but pleased at initiative). So, being intrapreneurial can be a career booster. Companies don't want employees who just clock in; they love those who think about improving the business^[16].

32. Mention how intrapreneurs often get special projects or even spin-off businesses. On the flip side, note: if a company doesn't listen to intrapreneurs, they might leave and become entrepreneurs on their own (many startups are born from employees leaving to do something themselves because their idea wasn't adopted).
33. Encourage them to have a proactive attitude: If they see a chance to improve or a market need at work, they can analyze it and propose it professionally. Even if not every idea is accepted, good employers will value the effort.
34. Resources for Aspiring Entrepreneurs: Briefly point out that if someone does want to start a business, there are supports available - e.g., local chambers of commerce, entrepreneurship courses, small business grants for youth, etc. You might not delve deep here, but letting them know “you're not alone, there's help out there” can be motivating. Possibly mention that writing a full business plan is a next step and there are templates and advisors for that.
35. Close with Inspiration: Perhaps share a short inspirational quote or success story of a startup in their field. For example, *“Did you know the founder of XYZ (pick a relatable company) started as a vocational student just like you?”* Or *“One intrapreneur at a small tech firm created a new product line that became 50% of the company's business in two years.”* Remind them: whether they become entrepreneurs, intrapreneurs, or just use these skills in everyday work, thinking like an innovator will help them adapt to the future of work (which ties to our next module on future skills).

Practical Exercises and Group Activities

- Idea Generation Games: (as above: random word, problem brainstorm) to loosen creative thinking.
- Business Model Canvas Lite: If you want a more structured approach for advanced students, introduce a very simplified version of the Business Model Canvas: just sections for Product, Customer, Revenue (\$), Costs, and Key Partners. Groups fill these for their idea. But careful: keep it at the right level - might be too much for some, so use only if appropriate.
- Role-Play - Pitch to a Boss: A variant of presentations: have one student pretend to be a worker pitching an intrapreneurial idea to a boss (played by trainer or another student). The boss asks a couple of tough questions (e.g., cost? market?). This role-play can show the importance of preparation and confidence. The class can critique supportively - did the “employee” sell it well?

- Case Study - Failed Ideas: It could be interesting to examine a case of a failed business (a known local shop that closed) or a product flop (like New Coke, etc.) to discuss why it failed and what could be learned. However, given level 3-4, keep it simple and constructive.
- Brainstorm Intrapreneur Ideas: If some students have work experience, ask if they ever had an idea to improve something at work. Discuss why they did or didn't share it. What could help employees be more intrapreneurial? (This can bring up company culture aspects - maybe they say “my boss wouldn't listen” - then discuss how to present ideas so bosses do listen, etc.). It emphasizes that workplace innovation (module1) ties in here - intrapreneurship is essentially workplace innovation initiated by employees.

Assessment Methods

- ✓ Group Project Assessment: The entrepreneurial idea planning can be assessed. You might use a rubric for the presentation or written outline:
- ✓ Clarity of idea (did they explain what it is clearly?),
- ✓ Identification of customer/need,
- ✓ Consideration of feasibility (did they think of resources and challenges?),
- ✓ Creativity/originality. Since this is more formative, you can give collective feedback rather than grades, or if needed, assign a grade to the group's plan and presentation.
- ✓ Quiz/Test Questions:
- ✓ Define intrapreneurship in your own words (e.g., “employees acting like entrepreneurs within a company to innovate”^[25]).
- ✓ List two qualities of successful entrepreneurs (from those brainstormed).
- ✓ Give one example of an entrepreneurial opportunity in [student's trade] (tests if they can connect to their domain - e.g., a plumber might say “starting a 24/7 emergency plumbing service in my town”, etc. - there's no single right answer, you check if it's plausible and shows understanding of identifying a need).

- ✓ Scenario: “Maria works as a technician at a small factory. She has an idea to reduce machine downtime by using a new maintenance app. What kind of mindset is Maria showing? What should she do next?” (Answer: intrapreneurial; she should propose it to management with a plan, maybe test it on one machine to gather evidence).
- ✓ Reflection Essay: “Do you see yourself ever starting a business or leading a new project? Why or why not? If yes, in what area? If not, how could you still apply entrepreneurial thinking in your career?” This assesses their personal takeaway and understanding. Some may express they prefer stability - that’s fine, you look for acknowledgement of intrapreneurship value, etc.
- ✓ In-Class Participation: The contributions in brainstorming and pitching can be noted. Students who come up with ideas or show enthusiasm should be acknowledged. You might incorporate a participation grade or just qualitative feedback (“You showed great creativity in the idea session!”).
- ✓ Terminology Check: A quick matching or fill-in-the-blank for key terms: entrepreneur, intrapreneur, business plan, risk, innovation. (E.g., “An ____ is an employee who initiates new ideas within their company.”)
- ✓ Peer Assessment: If group work is graded, consider a light peer assessment component (each student writes one strength their teammate brought to the project). This not only engages them in evaluation but also highlights entrepreneurial team roles (one was the “idea person”, another the “organizer”, etc., reflecting how real startup teams have co-founders with different strengths).
- ✓ Worksheet or Template Submission: If you provided a planning template for the group activity, you could collect those. Even incomplete, they show thought process. Grade leniently focusing on understanding of components more than detailed accuracy.

(Resources for trainers:) Possibly include a basic Entrepreneurship glossary (e.g. define terms like startup, investor, profit, revenue, innovation, etc.) if needed. Also, a pointer to the EntreComp framework for reference (the trainer can draw ideas from it, such as the 3 competence areas: Ideas & Opportunities, Resources, Into Action - which our module inherently covered). But avoid overwhelming students with such frameworks explicitly.

Module 6: Communication and Change Management

Learning Objectives

- Understand the role of communication in the workplace, especially during times of change (new procedures, new technologies, organizational changes).
- Learn effective communication techniques: clear messaging, active listening, giving and receiving feedback.
- Identify common reactions to change (e.g. resistance, anxiety) and reasons behind them.
- Learn basic change management strategies suitable for small teams or SMEs: involving people in decisions, communicating clearly and early, training and support, etc.
- Demonstrate skills in communicating change through role-play (e.g. explaining a new policy to co-workers) and handling questions or concerns.

Background Context (for Teachers & Students)

Workplaces are always changing - whether it's adopting a new tool (like the digital tools we discussed), shifting to a new process, or even bigger changes like restructuring teams. How these changes are communicated and managed makes a huge difference in whether they succeed or fail. Studies have found that many organizational changes fail or face difficulties largely due to poor communication. In fact, research indicates around “70% of change initiatives fail”, often because employees were not properly informed or engaged[26][27]. Effective communication and change management can prevent confusion and reduce resistance, making transitions smoother[28].

For vocational learners, the relevance is twofold: - As employees, they will receive and react to changes. Understanding the process can help them cope better and even be proactive participants rather than passive resisters. - They may also be in positions (especially as they advance to team leads or supervisors) to implement changes or improvements (linking to intrapreneurship and workplace innovation). So they should know how to get their colleagues on board and avoid common pitfalls.

Communication skills are foundational in all modules (teamwork, customer service, etc.), but here we focus on communication during change because it's particularly challenging: people might feel uncertain or threatened, rumors can spread if communication isn't clear, etc. Good communication builds trust and buy-in. For example, if a company needs to introduce a new safety procedure, just handing out a memo might not work well - explaining *why* it's needed, how it benefits everyone, and allowing questions will yield better compliance and morale.

Key concepts:

- Transparent Communication: People handle change better when they know *what* is changing, *why* it's happening, *when* and *how* it will happen, and *who* it affects^[29]. These are the basic questions any change communication should answer clearly. If these aren't communicated, employees fill the gaps with assumptions (often negative or exaggerated).
- Timeliness and Channels: Communicate early enough so people aren't caught by surprise. Use multiple channels if needed (meetings for discussion, follow-up written summary for clarity, etc.). E.g., a small company might announce a change in a team meeting and then put details on a notice board or email for reference.
- Two-Way Communication: It's not just top-down telling. Good change management invites feedback and questions. Workers on the ground might have insights into potential problems or solutions for implementation. Also, letting people express concerns makes them feel heard, even if the change must happen regardless.
- Empathy and Acknowledgment: Change can be emotional (people worry about job security, workload, competence with new systems, etc.). Acknowledging these feelings is important. For example, a manager might say, "I know this new software might feel hard to learn at first. That's a normal feeling - we'll provide training and help each other out." This reduces fear and builds trust.
- Managing Resistance: Expect some resistance - that's normal. Reasons vary: fear of the unknown, comfort with status quo, lack of trust in management, poor understanding of the change's benefits, etc. One study showed *"29% of employees report that organizational change is not communicated clearly, leading to confusion and uncertainty"*^[27] and unclear communication fosters resistance. By improving clarity, you can reduce a major source of resistance.
- The Role of Leadership: Leadership isn't only top bosses; anyone leading a change (even a small team leader) needs to walk the talk. If management is not visibly supporting the change or is inconsistent, employees won't buy in^[30]. So, aligning leaders and having them champion the change is key.
- Continuous Communication: Not one-and-done. During a change (which might take days, weeks, months), ongoing updates keep people informed of progress and successes, and keep rumors at bay^[31]. People often need repetition to absorb new info, and as things evolve, updates are needed.

For students, incorporate that these skills apply even in small-scale settings: e.g., if you’re introducing a new method in a 5-person workshop, how you communicate it will affect if your co-workers cooperate. Also, these are life skills: any scenario where you want to influence others or navigate change (even personal life changes) benefits from good communication and empathy.

Trainer Instructions for Delivery

1. Warm-up - Bad vs. Good Communication Demo: Do a quick role-play (with a co-trainer or volunteer student, or just describe two scenarios):
2. Scenario A (bad): Trainer acts as a boss rushing in, “From tomorrow, we’re using a new machine. Figure it out. It’s a company decision.” Then leaves no room for questions.
3. Scenario B (good): Trainer says, “Next week, we’ll introduce a new machine to improve production speed. I wanted to let you know early. We will have a training session on Tuesday, and I’m happy to answer questions or hear concerns. This should help us reduce manual work and get orders out faster, which will benefit everyone.” Ask the class: “*How would you feel in each scenario?*” They’ll likely say confused, annoyed, or resistant in A; more comfortable or at least informed in B. Use this to highlight elements of good communication: clarity, reasons, timing, support, openness to input.
4. The 5 Ws of Change Communication: Write on board: What, Why, When, How, Who (maybe also “What’s in it for me?”). Explain that whenever something changes at work, these questions should be addressed:
5. What is changing specifically? (Scope and nature of change)
6. Why is it changing? (Rationale: e.g., market demand, efficiency, compliance, etc. - people need to understand the reason or they create their own, often cynical, reason.)
7. When will it happen? Timeline and key dates.
8. How will it happen? Implementation plan - training provided? Phases? New responsibilities?
9. Who will be affected or involved? And who to ask for help? (e.g., “Talk to supervisor X if you have issues.”)

10. And indeed, WIIFM - “What’s in it for me?” (employees will think this, so address benefits: safer, easier, more job security if company does well, etc., or if there are downsides like extra work, acknowledge and explain compensation or plan to manage that). This framework comes partly from communication best practices[29]. Emphasize that if you communicate these clearly, you tackle a lot of uncertainty that causes resistance.
11. Discuss Reactions to Change: Ask students how they feel when something big changes in their life unexpectedly (like a class schedule change or a new teacher or moving houses). Common feelings: anxious, annoyed, curious, stressed, sometimes excited (if it seems positive). Note them. Then connect to workplace: when a new policy or technology is introduced, employees might feel similarly. Explain why people resist change: fear of failure (“Will I be able to learn the new system?”), comfort with old ways, lack of trust in those making the change, or they simply don’t see the need (maybe things seemed fine). Story: maybe mention how a company tried to implement a new software but employees kept using the old method under the radar because they found new software confusing - likely due to insufficient training and poor explanation of benefits. Share a stat: *“Unclear change communication is widespread - about one-quarter to one-third of employees across age groups feel their organization doesn’t communicate change effectively”*[32]. That leads to rumors and stronger resistance. If you ask employees after a failed change what went wrong, a common answer: “Nobody told us what was going on” or “We didn’t understand why we were doing this.”
12. Strategies for Communication & Change:
13. Early Involvement: If possible, involve some employees in planning the change (even in giving input). People are more receptive to what they helped create. In a small business, this could mean a meeting to brainstorm solutions to a problem, then management decides a change with employee ideas considered. (Relate to participatory approach from Module 2.)
14. Clear Messaging: Cover the 5 Ws. Avoid jargon if speaking to staff not familiar with it[33]. For example, don’t just say “We’re implementing Lean Six Sigma methodology,” say in plain language what will be different in their daily work.
15. Multiple Channels: In SMEs, the main channel might be face-to-face meetings (which is great for interaction), followed up by a written note (WhatsApp group or notice board) for reference. Emphasize *face-to-face is often best for important changes* because it allows dialogue and shows respect.

16. Listen and Acknowledge: Encourage questions. If someone raises a concern, acknowledge it (“I understand you’re worried about X...”). Even if you can’t change the plan, showing empathy builds goodwill. If you don’t have an answer yet, be honest and commit to finding out.
17. Leadership Alignment: Make sure any supervisors all understand the change well and support it before announcing broadly. Mixed messages from different managers cause chaos.
18. Training & Support: Often resistance comes from feeling unprepared. Plan for training if skills are needed. Also designate “go-to people” for help (like a tech-savvy person to help others with new software). Mention how in one stat, companies that use more open communication approaches saw big improvements in employee emotions: “open communication can cut employee anger about change from 24% to 5% and increase hopefulness”^[34], because people feel supported.
19. Celebrate small wins: As change is implemented, highlight successes (“After 1 month, our new process reduced errors by 20% - great job everyone adapting!”). This builds momentum and shows the change’s benefits, converting skeptics.
20. Feedback loop: Provide ways for employees to give feedback during the transition (suggestion box, weekly brief check-ins, etc.)^[35]. They might spot issues management didn’t foresee, so you can adjust implementation. Also, it lets them vent to someone instead of just grumbling among themselves.
21. Role-play Activities: Now practice some scenarios:
22. Scenario 1: Announcing a Change: Pair up. One is a supervisor, one is a worker. The supervisor has to inform the worker that starting next week, the shop will extend working hours by 1 hour due to high demand (or any simple change like mandatory new safety gear, or moving to a different worksite). The “boss” should try to communicate it using the good practices (explain why - e.g., more orders to fulfill, it’ll benefit company and possibly overtime pay; how it will work; acknowledge it’s an inconvenience; maybe it’s temporary; allow questions). The “employee” can react with one concern or question (like “I have kids to pick up, how will I manage?” or “We’re already tired, won’t this affect quality?”). The boss should respond empathetically (maybe “We will adjust schedules flexibly where possible” or “We’re hiring an extra helper to ease the load”, etc., if those are plausible).

23. After a few minutes, have some pairs demonstrate to the group (voluntarily). Discuss what the “boss” did well or could improve.
24. Scenario 2: Handling Rumors/Resistance: Imagine a rumor is going around that the company might cut some jobs because a new machine is coming (common fear: tech replacing labor). Pick one student to be a worried employee telling a co-worker “I heard we might be laid off, this new machine is going to take our jobs.” Now discuss as a group how should management handle such rumors? (Answer: address it openly in communication - e.g., “There is a new machine, but it’s to increase capacity, not reduce staff; we actually need you to operate it with new skills - and we will train you.” If layoffs were possible, that’s a delicate matter but still better addressed honestly with support measures, rather than letting the grapevine go wild.)
25. This highlights the need to *get ahead of rumors with facts*. And if someone asks a question you didn’t think of, that’s valuable feedback to clarify in your next communication.
26. Listening Skills Exercise: Good communication is two-way, so practice listening. Do a quick exercise: one student speaks for 1 minute about a change they experienced (work, school, personal) and how it felt. Their partner practices *active listening* - nod, maintain eye contact, don’t interrupt, maybe paraphrase after: “So you felt upset when they changed the schedule last minute, right?” This builds empathy. Discuss: in change management, leaders must listen to employees’ concerns - sometimes just being heard reduces frustration. If an employee says “This new software is too complicated, I’m frustrated,” a good response is “I hear you; it’s a big shift. Let’s see which part is most confusing - maybe we can provide more training on that.” Versus a bad one: “Just deal with it, everyone has to do it.” Role-play a poor listener vs good listener to illustrate.
27. Plan a Communication - Group Task: Divide class into small groups. Give each a hypothetical change scenario relevant to their trades, e.g.:
28. *Construction crew*: starting next month, everyone must use a new safety harness system with slightly different procedures.
29. *Culinary team*: the restaurant is changing the menu and workflow in the kitchen to incorporate a new cuisine.
30. *Auto workshop*: implementing a new digital job tracking system instead of paper job cards. Each group acts as management and must draft a simple communication plan or key message points for the staff. They should outline:

31. What’s the change and why (rationale).
32. How to announce it (meeting, demo, etc.),
33. What support is provided (training, trial period, etc.),
34. How to handle questions/feedback (maybe a follow-up meeting or an open-door policy during rollout).
35. Potential concerns employees might have and how to address them proactively in the announcement. After 10 minutes, have groups share their plan or even enact how they would announce it. Provide feedback and fill any gaps.
36. Emphasize key point: *Communication is not just talking, it’s also listening. And change management is not just telling people to change, it’s guiding and supporting them through the change.* Summarize that effective communication can significantly increase the chance a change will succeed - one source noted that companies with effective change communication are much more likely to achieve their change goals^[36]. If done poorly, even a technically good change can fail because people won’t adopt it properly (lack of understanding or motivation).
37. Tie to Prior Modules: Note how this module integrates prior themes:
38. If you involve employees in change (Module 2’s participatory problem solving), they’ll accept it more.
39. If it’s a digital tool change (Module 3), communicating why it’s better and training well is crucial.
40. If it’s sustainability (Module 4) - e.g., new recycling policy - you need to clearly explain the importance and how to do it.
41. If it’s a new venture (Module 5 intrapreneurship) - convincing your team or boss on that idea is basically change communication. So these skills are part of the holistic toolkit they’re developing.

Practical Exercises and Group Activities

- Role-Plays: as above, practicing announcements and responses. You can create multiple mini-scenarios and rotate roles so many get a chance.

- Case Study Video: If available, show a short video snippet of a leader communicating a change (some corporate training videos or even a TED/Talk on change). Have students critique it.
- The “Grapevine” Game: Similar to telephone game. Whisper a “change announcement” to one student, who whispers to next, etc., final person says it out loud. Compare with original - usually distorted. Point: informal word-of-mouth can distort messages; better to communicate clearly and broadly to everyone to minimize distortions.
- Feedback Form Design: Have students design a simple feedback form or survey an employer could use post-change (e.g., “Do you feel you have enough information about the new process? Yes/No, Any concerns?, etc.). This emphasizes creating channels for feedback.
- Change Plan Checklist: Provide a mock checklist that managers might use to plan a change (covering things we discussed). See if students can fill any missing items after all the discussion. This reinforces the systematic approach.

Assessment Methods

- ✓ Observation of Role-Play: Use a checklist or rubric to assess how well students apply communication tactics in role-plays. For example, did the “manager” convey the why, did they invite questions, use a good tone, etc. This can be formative or part of participation marks.
- ✓ Written Quiz:
- ✓ Define change management in a sentence (e.g. guiding people through change via planning, communication, etc.).
- ✓ Why is communication important during change? (Expected: prevents confusion, reduces resistance, builds trust[\[6\]\[27\]](#)).
- ✓ A scenario question: “Your company is introducing a new quality control procedure that requires extra paperwork, and many employees are upset. List three things you would do to communicate and implement this change successfully.” (Possible answers: explain the purpose (e.g. improve product quality which secures contracts hence jobs), train everyone on how to do the paperwork efficiently, assure that their concerns (like it’s time-consuming) are heard and maybe adjust workload accordingly, assign a mentor for first weeks to help, etc.)

- ✓ True/False: “If employees are resistant to change, the best approach is to enforce the rules strictly and not discuss it.” (False - need to discuss, understand concerns).
- ✓ Short answer: “What are two common mistakes managers make in communicating change?” (Answers might include: not explaining why, not listening to employees, waiting too long to tell people, giving too little detail, or giving only one announcement and no follow-up).
- ✓ Group Plan Evaluation: If you did the group communication plan exercise, collect their written plans or evaluate their presentation. Check if they covered essential points (what, why, etc.), and provided a mechanism for questions/support. This shows understanding of structure.
- ✓ Reflection: “Recall a change you experienced (at work, school, etc.). How was it communicated and how did you feel? What would you have done differently if you were in charge?” Evaluate if they can critique based on principles learned.
- ✓ Peer Feedback on Communication Skills: After role-plays, you could have students give feedback to each other via a simple form (e.g., “Did your partner explain the change clearly? Did they listen to you?” yes/no). This engages them in analytical thinking about communication.
- ✓ Listening Quiz: You could do a quick test of listening: say a short change announcement orally and then have them write down key info (the 5Ws). See if they caught all - this is partly a listening comprehension exercise but ties to noting what info a good announcement contains.
- ✓ Workplace Document Creation: Perhaps as a practical assignment, each student writes a mock email or notice announcing a small change (like new break policy or equipment use rule). Grade on clarity and completeness of info, tone (professional and positive), etc. This assesses written communication ability in a realistic format.

(Additional materials: A Change Communication Checklist handout for reference could be given - summarizing steps to plan a change communication. And maybe a short list of “Do’s and Don’ts” - e.g., Do: be honest, use clear language, share timely; Don’t: hide bad news, use jargon, ignore employee input. This reinforces learning and is a tool they can actually use in the future.)

Module 7: Personal Future Skills

Learning Objectives

- Identify key “future skills” (21st-century skills) that are increasingly important in the evolving world of work, such as adaptability, continuous learning, digital literacy, critical thinking, and social skills.
- Self-assess their current strengths and gaps in these transversal skills.
- Develop a personal development plan to improve selected future skills (e.g. set a learning goal, find resources or habits to build that skill).
- Understand how trends like automation, AI, and globalization might affect their trade and what skills will help them stay resilient (for example, creativity and problem-solving in areas machines can’t easily replace, or ability to work with new technology).
- Adopt a mindset of lifelong learning and career adaptability, recognizing that their career path may change and that they can transfer skills between jobs.

Background Context (for Teachers & Students)

The world of work is changing faster than ever. New technologies (like AI, robotics, Industry 4.0), as well as social and economic shifts (like the push for green economy, gig economy, etc.), mean that some jobs will change and new jobs will emerge. According to projections, a significant portion of skills workers use today will become outdated in the next decade^{[37][38]}. For example, routine manual tasks might be automated, while jobs will require more problem-solving and digital interaction.

But this isn’t meant to scare; rather to highlight that the ability to adapt and keep learning is the most critical skill of all. As one report notes, employers expect about “39% of workers’ core skills to change by 2030”^[38]. In response, companies value employees who are resilient, flexible, and willing to retrain. In fact, “*resilience, flexibility and agility*” were listed right after analytical thinking as top core skills needed^[39].

What are Personal Future Skills? These are often called *transversal skills*, *transferable skills*, or *21st-century skills*. They are not job-specific (like welding or accounting), but rather abilities and attitudes that help you in any job and in navigating change. Examples include: - Adaptability & Learning to Learn: Being able to adjust to new conditions and pick up new skills or knowledge continuously. For instance, if a new machine is introduced, an adaptable worker says “Okay, let’s learn it” rather than resisting. - Critical Thinking & Problem Solving: The ability to analyze situations, think logically, and solve new problems. As routine tasks get automated, humans will focus more on solving complex or unexpected issues. - Creativity: Coming up with new ideas or approaches. AI might crunch data, but human creativity in arts, innovation, and tricky problem-solving remains crucial. - Collaboration & Communication: Working well with others (often in diverse teams) and communicating effectively. With more interconnected work (remote teams, cross-functional projects), this is key. - Digital Literacy: Comfort with using digital tools (not necessarily advanced coding, but being able to learn new software, understand basic digital concepts). We covered digital tools earlier; here it’s about the underlying skill of digital fluency. - Emotional Intelligence: Understanding and managing your own emotions and working well with others’ emotions - empathy, teamwork, conflict resolution. With more automation, the uniquely human, social skills become a bigger differentiator. - Resilience & Stress Tolerance: Being able to cope with change and setbacks without giving up. For example, if job roles shift or there’s a pandemic (like COVID was a massive sudden change), resilient individuals find ways to adapt, re-skill if needed, and maintain mental well-being. - Initiative & Self-management: Being proactive in your career and work, setting goals for yourself, managing your time and learning. In a fast-changing world, waiting for someone to always tell you what to do puts you at a disadvantage. Employers appreciate those who manage themselves well and take initiative.

In Europe, frameworks like ESCO or the LifeComp and “transversal skills frameworks” highlight these, and global reports (like WEF’s Future of Jobs) consistently mention these top skills (analytical thinking, active learning, complex problem-solving, etc.)^[40]. For instance, the WEF Future of Jobs 2025 lists analytical thinking, active learning, and complex problem-solving as top skills, along with resilience, stress tolerance, and flexibility rising in importance^[39].

For vocational learners at EQF 3-4, the message is: Your technical skills are your entry ticket, but these broader skills will determine how far you go and how secure you remain in a changing job market. SMEs particularly need flexible workers who can wear multiple hats as things change. Also, to possibly grow into roles like team leader or adapt to new technologies in your trade, these skills are essential.

This module is a bit different from others - it's about *personal development*. We ask students to reflect on themselves and plan how to grow. It's about mindset: *being future-ready*.

Trainer Instructions for Delivery

1. Future Scenario Brainstorm: Ask students: *“What do you think your job (or industry) will look like 10 years from now?”* Give a moment to think, then share. They might say some machines will be more advanced, maybe some tasks will be eliminated, or that new techniques will be used. Write down key changes they foresee (automation, more digital, stricter environment rules, etc.). If they struggle, add known trends: e.g., cars might be mostly electric - so auto mechanics will need to know high-voltage systems; construction may use 3D printing for some components; or simply that they might communicate with customers via apps rather than phone. Then ask: *“What skills will workers need to thrive in those changes?”* If electric cars, mechanics need to learn electrical engineering basics (so, continuous learning); if more automation, they need to maybe manage/maintain robots (digital/technical skill) and do the complex tasks machines can't (problem-solving); if new processes come frequently, need adaptability; if more diverse teams, need teamwork and communication; etc. Help them make the link: technical upskilling will happen (of course learning new tech), but underlying all is the ability to adapt and keep learning.
2. Top 10 Skills for 2025 (or relevant year): You can present an abbreviated list from a source like the WEF 2023 report. For example, say: *“Research from the World Economic Forum shows that the most in-demand skills by 2025 include analytical thinking, active learning, complex problem-solving, critical thinking, creativity, leadership, resilience, and flexibility”*^{[40][39]}. Maybe write a simplified list:
 3. Analytical/Critical Thinking
 4. Problem-Solving
 5. Creativity
 6. Resilience/Flexibility
 7. Ability to learn new skills
 8. Collaboration/Teamwork
 9. Leadership & Social influence (if they aim to progress)

10. Technological use & Development (digital literacy, though not everyone needs to be a programmer, understanding AI helps for example)
11. Empathy/Emotional intelligence (for customer service and teamwork)
12. (The list can vary, but cover the essence). Discuss each briefly, relating to examples in work life. E.g., “Active learning” means you know how to teach yourself new things — if tomorrow a new machine is introduced, an active learner will figure out how to operate it maybe by reading the manual or watching tutorials without needing a formal course for everything.
13. Self-Reflection Activity: Distribute a Future Skills Self-Assessment worksheet. This might list 5-7 key skills with simple rating (1-5 or “I need to work on this / I’m okay / I’m strong at this”) and a prompt for evidence or example. For instance:
14. Adaptability: How do you react to new or unexpected situations? Give an example.
15. Learning new things: When is the last time you learned a skill outside of school? How did you do it?
16. Problem-solving: Do you enjoy solving tricky problems? Give an example of a problem you solved (could be in daily life).
17. Communication: Do you feel you communicate well? (Maybe ask them to think of a time they had to explain something or resolve a misunderstanding).
18. Teamwork: etc. Give them time to fill quietly. Encourage honesty - this is for their own growth, not to grade harshly. Then they can voluntarily share one strength and one “to improve” if comfortable. The idea is to raise self-awareness. Many might realize “Hmm, I haven’t had to be very adaptable yet” or “I’m good at working with others but not so confident in learning tech on my own.” That’s fine.
19. Personal Goal Setting: Explain that any skill can be improved with practice and learning. It’s not fixed. So, have each student pick one or two skills they want to develop more. Perhaps one that’s a clear weakness, and one they think will be crucial in their desired career. For example, someone shy might choose communication, another might choose time management or leadership. In the worksheet or separately, have them write a mini action plan:
20. Which skill to improve.

21. Why - how will it benefit them or why do they care.
22. How to improve it - brainstorm some methods (e.g., for communication: volunteer to present in class or join a speaking club; for digital literacy: take an online tutorial on Excel; for learning to learn: try a free online course in something small to practice self-learning; for English language if relevant; for creativity: maybe start a hobby that encourages creativity).
23. Set a realistic short-term goal, like over the next month or during their next internship. E.g., “During my internship, I will ask for feedback from my supervisor at least twice (to improve communication and initiative).” Or “I will learn basics of [a relevant software] on my own using YouTube tutorials for 1 hour each week.” Circulate to help with ideas. Emphasize, it doesn’t have to be big. Lifelong learning is continuous small steps.
24. Share Plans (optional): If comfortable, let a few share what skill they plan to work on and their strategy. Others might get ideas from it. Encourage peer suggestions too. For instance, if one says “I want to improve English proficiency,” others might suggest apps like Duolingo, watching movies with subtitles, etc. This also normalizes that everyone has something to improve - it's not remedial, it's normal for growth.
25. Introduce Lifelong Learning concept: Explain that formal schooling ends, but learning shouldn't. Many companies now invest in retraining workers; also many resources are available (adult education, online courses, on-the-job training). Being proactive is key. For example, mention that *“60% of workers will require reskilling by 2027”* according to WEF^[41], and good news: *“82% of employers plan to invest in training their staff”*^[42]. So opportunities will be there, but the individuals who take advantage of them will benefit most. Also mention micro-credentials or short courses - in the future, people might accumulate small qualifications throughout life as needed. EQF 3-4 learners might not go to university, but they might do specific courses (like a certificate in 3D printing, or a course on team leadership) as their career demands.
26. Discuss Career Adaptability: Bring up that career paths are not linear now. Someone might start as a technician, then with new skills become a supervisor, or switch to a related field. For instance, a mechanic might evolve into an electric vehicle specialist, or an office secretary might become a social media marketer for the firm with digital upskilling. Encourage openness to opportunities. A phrase: *“Your career is a marathon, not a sprint, and sometimes the route changes - future skills are your toolkit to navigate.”*

27. Resilience and Coping: Touch on the fact that change can be stressful (like we did in Module 6). Building resilience is partly mindset (viewing change as challenge not threat) and partly healthy habits (stress management, work-life balance). Encourage them to maintain a network (colleagues, professional groups) - networking is a future skill too, as sometimes jobs are found through networks. Also, if something in their career goes wrong (like job loss), resilience helps them bounce back - update CV, retrain, not lose hope. Perhaps share an anecdote of someone who pivoted careers successfully.

28. Wrap-up Inspiration: Summarize the main future skills identified. Perhaps mention that learning these skills is an ongoing process - this course gave them a start in many (teamwork, problem-solving, etc.). They should continue to seek experiences that grow these skills. Highlight how being strong in these areas can set them apart. Many employers say they can teach someone technical tasks, but they really value those with good soft skills and willingness to learn, because those employees grow with the company. A quote from an employer or study might be useful if available, like *“Employers often prioritize attitude and adaptability over specific technical know-how, since technology can be taught, but mindset is developed.”* Encourage them to revisit their personal plan periodically and update it - essentially managing their own career like a project. They are the CEO of “Me Inc.” in a sense.

29. Ending Activity - Future Skills Trivia or Poster:

- Trainers could do a quick trivia quiz on what skills will be essential, based on earlier content (just to reinforce).
- Or have them create a vision board or poster of “My Future Me” where they write or draw themselves in 10 years with the skills they cultivated and maybe the position they aspire to. Something positive and forward-looking to conclude the program.

Practical Exercises and Group Activities

- Self-Assessment and Goal Setting: (As done, these are introspective but crucial.)

- **Skill-Building Challenge:** Challenge each student to do one thing in the coming week outside their comfort zone to practice a skill - e.g., speak up with an idea (communication/confidence), solve a puzzle or brainteaser (problem-solving/analytical), learn a new function in a software they use (digital learning), do an activity that requires creativity (draw, write, DIY), or meet someone new/ have a conversation (social skills). Later, have a brief check-in on what they did and learned.
- **Adaptability Game:** Play “what if?” scenarios: In small groups, give a scenario like “Your job description suddenly changes to include client social media promotion, how do you adapt?” They discuss actions (take a course, ask colleagues for tips, experiment with social media tools). This emphasizes proactive learning and attitude.
- **Resume of the Future:** Ask them to imagine writing a CV 10 years from now. What new skills or roles might be on it? This can be creative but also reflective of how they plan to grow. They can share one item from their “future CV” if they want.
- **Learning Resources Hunt:** Provide a list of free/affordable learning resources (websites like Coursera, YouTube channels, local training centers, books, etc.). Have students each pick one resource that could help with a skill and present how to access it. (E.g., “Khan Academy for math basics,” “LinkedIn Learning course on teamwork,” “Local Chamber of Crafts evening class on CNC machines”). This exposes them to the idea that lots of learning is at their fingertips.
- **Mentorship Talk:** If possible, bring in a slightly older apprentice or a young professional to talk about how they had to learn new skills or adapt after graduation. Hearing real stories often inspires students to take future-readiness seriously.

Assessment Methods

- ✓ **Self-Assessment Completion:** Since this module is personal, the “grading” might be more on participation and effort rather than right/wrong. You can mark if they completed the self-reflection and plan meaningfully (not just one-word answers). This can be considered in a portfolio rather than a test.
- ✓ **Quiz on future trends:** Possibly include one or two questions in a test about why future skills are needed (e.g., “Name two reasons why continuous learning is important for your career.” Expected: technology changes, jobs evolve, etc., referencing data like skill disruption^[38]).

- ✓ Action Plan Evaluation: If you treat their personal development plan as an assignment, you can check if it’s SMART-ish (Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, Time-bound). For example, student wrote “Improve English by watching one English video per day for a month.” That’s specific and measurable. You can give feedback like “Good plan - maybe also try speaking practice by reading aloud or finding a partner.” The aim is to encourage thoughtful planning.
- ✓ Class Participation: Evaluate how engaged they were in discussions about future changes and skills. This is more qualitative.
- ✓ Presentation or Essay: Perhaps an essay: “The skill I believe will be most important in my future career is ___, because... and I plan to develop it by...”. Grade on understanding and insight.
- ✓ Scenario Response: Provide a scenario in a written exam: e.g., “Automation will take over repetitive tasks in your field. How can a worker remain valuable in this situation?” Expected: mention upskilling, focusing on complex tasks, adaptability, maybe maintenance of the automation, etc., essentially reflecting adaptability and continuous learning.
- ✓ Terminology Check: define terms like “lifelong learning”, “resilience”, “digital literacy” in simple words. This checks understanding of concepts.
- ✓ Portfolio: If maintaining a student portfolio, items like the self-assessment, personal plan, and evidence of skill practice (maybe their reflection on the challenge they did) can be included. Not graded per se, but reviewed and commented on, culminating the course.
- ✓ Follow-up (if possible): If you or their tutors meet them after some time, you could informally check if they pursued any goals. Even as feedback for yourself, to know which strategies stuck.

(Encourage positivity: Remind them that they have already been building these skills through the course: working in teams, solving problems, communicating. So they are not starting from zero at all. This final module ties it all together and encourages them to continue the journey on their own initiative.)

Conclusion of the Training Program:

By completing or or all of these seven modules, VET learners have gained a well-rounded set of additional qualifications in workplace innovation and personal development. They learned how to contribute to innovation in their jobs (by generating ideas, solving problems collaboratively, using digital tools, and promoting sustainable practices), how to initiate and manage change (through entrepreneurial thinking, effective communication and leadership in change situations), and how to continuously develop themselves (adapting to future needs and committing to lifelong learning). These competencies will help them succeed and be proactive in any workplace, making them valuable employees and perhaps the future innovators and leaders in their trades.

Next Steps for Trainers: The materials provided in each module (objectives, context, instructions, activities, and assessment methods) can be adapted to specific industries and class durations.

By the end of the program, learners should not only have new knowledge but also greater confidence in their ability to navigate and shape the modern workplace.

Example Worksheets for each of the seven modules

These worksheets are designed to support learning activities within the seven training modules. They offer example tasks, reflection prompts, and structured answer spaces that help learners apply key concepts to their own work experiences.

The worksheets are not fixed templates. Trainers are encouraged to adapt, shorten, expand, or replace tasks based on the needs of their learners, the specific vocational field, and the training context. The examples provided serve as guidance and may be modified freely to fit different situations or learning objectives.

The aim is to provide practical, flexible tools that help learners engage with workplace innovation topics and develop skills relevant to EQF Levels 3 and 4.

Module 1: Introduction to Workplace Innovation

Describe in your own words what workplace innovation means.

List three examples of workplace improvements you have observed or could imagine.

Identify one routine task that could be improved and explain why.

Explain how innovation can support safety or efficiency in a company.

Describe a situation where a small change made work easier.

Module 2: Participatory Problem Solving and Teamwork

Describe a problem in your workplace and why it occurs.

List four possible solutions developed during teamwork.

Explain which solution your team chose and why.

Identify the specific role you played in the team exercise.

Describe a teamwork challenge you experienced and how it was handled.

Module 3: Digital Tools for Innovation

Choose one digital tool and describe its purpose.

Explain how the tool improves workflow or communication.

Complete a small task with the tool and describe the outcome.

Identify one digital skill you want to improve and why.

Describe a risk connected to digital tool use and how to avoid it.

Module 4: Sustainability and Social Responsibility

List three examples of sustainable behaviour at work.

Identify a source of waste and propose an improvement.

Describe how sustainability influences company decisions.

Explain the environmental impact of one work-related activity.

Suggest an initiative your company could implement to be more responsible.

Module 5: Entrepreneurship and Intrapreneurship

Describe an idea that could improve work in your company.

Explain who benefits from your idea and how.

List the resources needed to test or implement your idea.

Identify a risk connected to your idea and propose a solution.

Describe an example of intrapreneurship you have seen.

Module 6: Communication and Change Management

Describe a difficult communication situation at work.

Explain two different ways to respond in such a situation.

List communication barriers you have observed.

Describe a change at work and how employees reacted.

Explain what makes communication clear and effective.

Module 7: Personal Future Skills

List your strengths and explain how they help you at work.

Identify one personal development goal for the next three months.

Describe steps you will take to reach this goal.

Explain what motivates you to learn new skills.

Rate your current time-management skills and suggest improvements.

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